source and is composed in a very different style. There is nothing in these early chapters that commits us to any particular scientific view of the origins of the world or man, or that would exclude the evolution hypothesis.

* Gen 3:15, *he shall bruise your head:* i.e., the seed of the woman, that is, mankind descended from Eve, will eventually gain the victory over the powers of evil. This victory will, of course, be gained through the work of the Messiah who is *par excellence* the seed of the woman.

The Latin Vulgate has the reading *ipsa conteret*, "she shall bruise." Some Old Latin manuscripts have this reading, and it occurs also in St. Augustine, *De Genesi contra Manichaeos*, II, which is earlier than St. Jerome's translation. It could be due originally to a copyist's mistake, which was then seen to contain a genuine meaning—namely, that Mary, too, would have her share in the victory, inasmuch as she was mother of the Savior.

* Gen 4:1: The story of Cain and Abel has the purpose of showing the effects of sin within society, the fratricide of Cain leading to the vengeance of Lamech and so to the Flood. We are, however, no longer in the first age of humanity, as can be seen from verses 14, 17, etc.

* Gen 4:26: *Seth* takes the place of the murdered Abel and is the ancestor of Noah. In Ex 3:14 and 6:2–3 we find another account of the origins of Yahwism.

* Gen 5:1, *generations:* It should be noted that these genealogies are selective and schematic, and the numbers, as often in the Old Testament, are symbolic.

* Gen 6:2, *sons of God* could mean simply "divine beings," as elsewhere in the Old Testament. The writer, however, may be using an old story or myth to point out the progressive degradation of mankind before the Flood and to warn against the evil effects of intermarriage either of the descendants of Seth with the Kenites or, more probably, of the Israelites with the native populations of Canaan.

* Gen 6:11: Here begins the Flood narrative formed of two almost parallel accounts. This fact explains the existence of repetitions and discrepancies. It is, in places, remarkably similar to other Flood stories from the ancient Near East.

* Gen 10:1, *generations:* This "table of the nations" makes use of old material to show how all the nations of the world as then known have

descended from the generation that survived the Flood. It was from this world that Abraham was called to be the father of the chosen people.

* Gen 11:1–9: The tower of Babel (= Babylon) is taken as a symbol of political power, empire-building, and the civilization that opposes God's plan. The tower was probably a ziggurat, i.e., Babylonian temple.

* Gen 12:1–3: With Abraham's call, sacred history in the strict sense begins. The promise theme runs through the whole patriarchal history, e.g., 18:18; 28:14.

* Gen 14:18, *Melchizedek* was later taken as a Messianic figure (Ps 110:4) and interpreted in the New Testament as foreshadowing Christ, whose priesthood (including the offering of bread and wine) exceeds that of the Old Testament; cf. Heb 7:1–7.

* Gen 15:1: The Vulgate has "I am thy protector, and thy reward exceeding great." There was, however, at this stage, no idea of a reward in a future life.

* Gen 16:1–4: The practice suggested by Sarai, involving as it did polygamy, was in accord with moral standards at that time and is referred to in legal codes of the period.

* Gen 19:1: The Sodom episode, so often referred to in the Old and New Testaments, expresses the abhorrence of the true Israelite for unnatural sin and the violation of the sacred duty of hospitality, cf. Judg 19:11–30.

* Gen 22:1–19: The sacrifice of Isaac, while reprobating the practice of human sacrifice then in use among the Canaanites, gives a magnificent example of Abraham's faith and obedience, as also does 18:1–15; cf. Rom 4 and Heb 11:8–12.

* Gen 22:6: Isaac, carrying the wood up the mountain for the sacrifice, has often been seen as a figure of Christ carrying his cross to die on Golgotha.

* Gen 25:19: With the birth of Esau and Jacob we enter a new narrative cycle. Jacob, renamed Israel, is represented as the ancestor of the twelve tribes and, therefore, of the whole people; cf. Deut 26:5.

* Gen 28:10–22: This narrative explains and justifies the use of what had formerly been a Canaaaite sanctuary, Bethel. The ladder seems to represent the ziggurat, which was a temple with steps leading to a platform at the top.

* Gen 32:24–32: The meaning of this, one of the oldest and most mysterious narratives in Genesis, remains obscure. It is intended to explain the place name Penuel, which means "face of God."

* Gen 37:2: From this point the book of Genesis is chiefly concerned with the Joseph story, which is full of the sense of divine providence. It has, as might be expected, a markedly Egyptian character.

* Gen 49:1–27: In their present form these "Oracles of Jacob," blessings pronounced upon his sons as epitomizing the twelve tribes, date from the period of the early monarchy.

THE BOOK OF EXODUS

* This book, made up of various traditions of different dates, deals with two events, the deliverance from Egypt and the Sinai covenant, which, closely linked together, form the basis of Old Testament faith. It is dominated by the personality of Moses. Back to text.

* Ex 3:14: The translation is uncertain; it is, therefore, difficult to decide whether this is a refusal to disclose the name or an explanation of the divine title Yahweh revealed immediately afterward.

* Ex 7:14: Here begins the story of the ten plagues. Again, the narrative is composite, and originally different traditions knew of different numbers of plagues. All, however, lead up to the climax of the death of the first–born. Some of the plagues correspond to natural phenomena that are known to occur, or to have occurred in the past, in Egypt.

* Ex 12:1: The feast of the Passover, the regulations for which are given here, commemorates the deliverance from Egypt. The feast of unleavened bread would probably have been added only after the entry into Canaan. The Passover foreshadows the sacrifice of Jesus (1 Cor 5:7).

* Ex 16:14: The mysterious manna may have been a substance secreted by the tamarisk or perhaps by an insect that feeds on its leaves and is edible. In the New Testament it is a type of the Eucharist; cf. Jn 6:31–35, 48–51.

* Ex 19:3: The covenant makes Israel the people of God and binds them to the fulfilment of the commandments; it is concluded in chapter 24.

* Ex 20:1–17: The Ten Commandments, in their original form even briefer than here, are found in a different version in Deut 5:6–21.

* Ex 40:34: *the cloud* and the fire, that is, the *glory*, are ways of representing at the same time the presence and the transcendence of God.

THE BOOK OF LEVITICUS

* As the name suggests, this book is almost exclusively concerned with the regulation of the religious life of Israel by the Levitical priesthood. Although its underlying concept of Israel as a holy people contains an

element of permanent importance, the law as such, except for those parts that Christ expressly sanctioned, is not binding on Christians. Back to text.

* Lev 11:1: These regulations concerning what is ritually pure or impure depend, for the most part, on circumstances peculiar to that time; e.g., animals, such as the pig, used in pagan sacrifices. Some correspond to ancient taboos.

* Lev 17:1: The so-called "Code of Holiness" (chapters 17–26) implies an exalted idea of the holiness and otherness of the God of Israel.

THE BOOK OF NUMBERS

* The title of this book is explained by the census with which it opens. It is composed of both history and legislation, and, though edited finally by the priests after the Exile, it contains much ancient material. Back to text.

* Num 11:16–30: The account of the election of the seventy elders emphasizes the charismatic or prophetic basis of authority in the community.

* Num 21:4–9: The bronze serpent may have been the standard or symbol of the tribe of Levi, to which Moses and Aaron belonged. In Jn 3:14 it becomes a type of the saving cross of Christ.

* Num 22:21–35: The story of Balaam and his donkey is of popular origin. The oracles of this foreign seer, especially the fourth (24:15–19), refer to the Messianic king of the future, of whom David is the type.

THE BOOK OF DEUTERONOMY

* The title comes from the mistranslation of 17:18 in the Greek version (the Septuagint) and really means "a second copy of the law." The book comprises the so-called "Deuteronomic Code of Law" (chapters 12–26), edited within the framework of two discourses attributed to Moses represented as prophet and lawgiver. The whole is rounded off with a third discourse, a psalm, and an account of Moses' death and burial. The central theme of Deuteronomy is the election of Israel as the people of God by means of the covenant. Back to text.

* Deut 4:32–40: This passage gives the clearest and most eloquent expression of Israel's consciousness of its election as the people of God.

* Deut 4:41: The beginning of the second discourse of Moses containing the Deuteronomic version of the Ten Commandments; cf. Ex 20:1–17.

* Deut 6:4–9: The recital thrice daily of this text, plus two others, is the principal practice of piety of the religious Jew; it is called the Shema

(“Hear”). It contains the greatest commandment of the Law, that is, the love of the covenant-God (cf. Mt 22:37), and a clear statement of monotheism.

* Deut 12:2: This law, enforcing one single place of worship, connects historically with the religious reform of Josiah just before the Exile in the opinion of many scholars; cf. 2 Kings 22–23.

* Deut 18:18: The prophet like Moses mentioned here refers either to the prophetic movement as a whole or to an individual, either Joshua (successor of Moses) or Samuel. The New Testament sees here a reference to the Messiah; cf. Jn 1:21; Acts 3:22; 7:37.

* Deut 24:1: Divorce was permitted in Old Testament times on account of “hardness of heart”; Jesus, however, insists that it was not in the original plan of God (Mt 19:7–9).

THE BOOK OF JOSHUA

* This book continues the narrative from the death of Moses (Deut 34), through the conquest of Canaan, down to the great covenant-renewal at Shechem. The account of the conquest is stylized and summarized: thus, not all the tribes entered the land together as here described, the operation was not so free of difficulties and even failures as we might assume after a reading of this book, and the occupation of the whole country could not have been carried out by Joshua in person. Judges 1 gives a somewhat different and complementary version. Back to text.

* Josh 6:1: Here, as elsewhere, the history has been worked over in accordance with certain theological ideas.

* Josh 6:17: Following the indications elsewhere in the Old Testament, it would appear that the ban, that is, the physical destruction of the enemy in obedience to the Deity, was practiced much less than a reading of Joshua might suggest. Despite the high religious principles that motivated it, it must be seen in the light of the imperfect stage of moral development reached at that time.

* Josh 3:7–17: The crossing of the Jordan is described in such a way as to bring out the theological parallelism with the crossing of the Red Sea (or, Sea of Reeds); both are seen as due to the direct intervention of God.

* Josh 10:12–14: Joshua’s apostrophe to the sun occurs in a fragment quoted from an old collection of epic material, and the quotation goes on beyond verse 12. This would make a literal interpretation of this event undesirable. It appears from the narrative that a great storm occurred at the same time as the attack and powerfully helped toward the Israelite victory

(verse 11). It is this sign of divine aid that is so graphically apostrophized in the following poetic fragment (verses 12–13).

* Josh 13–21: This section consists of topographical indications: the possessions and boundaries of the tribes and other ethnic groups, and a list of the cities of refuge.

* Josh 24:1: The full gathering of the tribes at Shechem for a renewal of the covenant sealed the conquest and the final apportioning of the land. It seems to indicate the conversion to the worship of Yahweh of those Hebrews who did not go down to Egypt.

THE BOOK OF JUDGES

* This book, which has been edited at least twice, fills in the period from the settlement to the monarchy. This was a period of crisis that gave rise to "saviors" raised up by God to meet these critical situations. The deeds of six of these are recounted at some length: Othniel, Ehud, Deborah (and Barak), Gideon, Jephthah, Samson; there are also six "minor" judges who are given only a short notice: Shamgar, Tola, Jair, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon. The book ends with two appendixes (chapters 17–21). Back to text.

* Judg 1:1: This first chapter describes the difficulties and defeats of the conquest.

* Judg 2:11–19: This passage gives the theological scheme of the book according to which the episodic history is presented. It comes from an editor inspired by the ideas of Deuteronomy and resembles closely the scheme according to which the kings, beginning with Solomon, are assessed and judged.

* Judg 5:1: The song of Deborah gives an alternative to the prose account of the previous chapter. Though touched up by later editors, it is very ancient and gives a valuable picture of the state of Israel in the thirteenth century B.C..

* Judg 8:23: It appears from the sequel that Gideon did in fact become a king even if he refused the title; but the idea of an hereditary monarchy was still unacceptable, as the following history of Abimelech shows.

* Judg 11:39: Human sacrifice, common in Canaan and surrounding lands, was never permitted in Israel; cf. Lev 18:21. The few cases we find were due to foreign influence or to an erroneous conscience; cf. 2 Sam 21:4–6; 2 Kings 23:10.

* Judg 13:1: The "Samson cycle" (chapters 13–16) is built on the theme of the broken vow; cf. 13:4–5. This gives a religious character to what

otherwise has the appearance of profane literature.

* Judg 17–21: Extracts from tribal tradition which give a dark picture of the times.

THE BOOK OF RUTH

* This charming tale of family life in the countryside of Bethlehem during the period of the judges is imbued with a deeply religious spirit. It is a story of family devotion and of piety toward one's ancestors. The book has significance for the ancestry of David and the Messiah. Though Jewish in feeling, it is not narrowly so; indeed, Boaz goes beyond what is strictly required by the law and, though the book insists that Israel's faith must remain uncontaminated, yet it also says it must be made available to all. The call of the Gentiles is foreseen. There is no certainty about the date of the book. It was probably written during the period of the kingship, though some think it was composed after the Exile. Back to text.

THE FIRST BOOK OF SAMUEL

* The First and Second Books of Samuel (the First and Second Books of Kings): Samuel was traditionally supposed to have written these books—hence the title. The Latin Vulgate, following the Greek tradition, links these books with 1 and 2 Kings, calling them 1–4 Kings (Greek, 1–4 Kingdoms). 1 and 2 Samuel cover the early period of the monarchy and are, in fact, composed of two main traditions; this at times makes the sequence of events difficult to follow. The narrative makes plain the difficulty of centralizing the government of the tribes. David's character and achievement are well brought out, and there is special emphasis on the Messianic importance of both. Yet at the end the signs of possible schism are already manifest. The books were probably written during the period of the divided monarchy. Back to text.

* 1 Sam 1:3, *Shiloh:* At this time, the central sanctuary of the tribes and the residence of the ark, the visible assurance of the presence of Yahweh, Lord of the hosts of Israel.

* 1 Sam 2:1–10: This song, though certainly touched up at a later period (e.g., the reference to a king in verse 10), is meant to express Hannah's sentiments. It has profoundly influenced the Magnificat.

* 1 Sam 2:18, *ephod:* The ephod was either a distinctive priestly garment as here, or a means of divination used by the priest, possibly a container for the sacred lots; cf. 2:28.

* 1 Sam 3:1: This account of the prophetic vocation of Samuel (cf. Is 6) is meant to begin a new chapter in the spiritual history of Israel.
* 1 Sam 4:1: Here begins a new phase in the epic struggle against the Philistines, which the editor has skilfully woven into the story of the ark and of Samuel.
* 1 Sam 4:21, *Ichabod:* The name means "The Glory is not"; i.e., the glory of the Lord enthroned over the ark has departed. Then followed the years during which the sanctuary of Shiloh was desolate and of which Jeremiah long afterward was acutely conscious; cf. Jer 7:12, 14; 26:6.
* 1 Sam 7:2: The story of the ark, which comes from a special source, is continued in 2 Sam 6.
* 1 Sam 8:10ff: Choosing a king. Two accounts are discernible—a monarchist and an antimonarchist. In the absence of a central sanctuary and in an atmosphere of defeat, one section of the people demanded a king to re-establish their fortunes; the others preferred to leave it to God to raise up leaders when necessary, as in the days of the judges.
* 1 Sam 9:13, *high place:* It was customary in early Israel to worship God on raised platforms or hilltops, as the Canaanites did their gods. Later such practices were forbidden as leading to idolatry, and worship was allowed only in Jerusalem; cf. Deut 12:2ff.
* 1 Sam 10:5, *prophets:* An inferior kind of prophet who flourished for a time in Israel. They were quite different from the writing prophets, in that they cultivated states of ecstasy and even used musical instruments for the purpose.
* 1 Sam 11:8: These figures are probably a later insertion.
* 1 Sam 12:11, *Jerubbaal:* i.e., Gideon.
* 1 Sam 12:20–25: Samuel here summarizes the antimonarchist attitude; cf. Josh 24.
* 1 Sam 13:1: Acts 13:21 says Saul reigned forty years; but so did David (2 Sam 5:5). These must be round numbers, to indicate a fairly long rule.
* 1 Sam 14:38–42: This passage shows how the sacred lots were cast to find out God's will.
* 1 Sam 15:22–23: Samuel does not condemn sacrifices but says obedience is better.
* 1 Sam 18:25, *marriage present:* The usual payment for a bride.
* 1 Sam 19:20–24: cf. 10:5.

* 1 Sam 26:19, *Go, serve other gods:* They did not consider the possibility of worshiping Yahweh, the God of Israel, in a foreign land.

THE SECOND BOOK OF SAMUEL

* 2 Sam 1:26: Vulgate adds, “As the mother loves her only son, so did I love you.”

* 2 Sam 2:8, *Ish-bosheth:* “Man of shame.” The name was really Ish-baal, “Man or servant of Baal,” but the writer could not bring himself to pronounce so profane a name, especially as it belonged to an Israelite; cf. 1 Chron 8:33; 9:39, where the name is given as Esh-baal.

* 2 Sam 2:14, *play:* He meant “do battle.” The idea was to settle the matter by a fight between two select groups of soldiers.

* 2 Sam 5:1: The two chapters 5–6 represent the climax of David’s career with the establishment of Jerusalem as the political and religious center of Israel.

* 2 Sam 5:6, *the blind and the lame:* The meaning is, that the place was so strong that it could be defended even by the blind and the lame. But David took it by a stratagem, his men climbing secretly up a shaft from the spring Gihon. The place was ideal for a capital city.

* 2 Sam 7:1–29: The point of this prophecy is the establishment of David’s dynasty. Hence God says he will build David a house (verse 11). David thanks him suitably in a formal prayer (verses 18–29).

* 2 Sam 9:1: 2 Sam 9—1 Kings 2 (except 2 Sam 21–24) is the account of the struggle for the succession to David’s throne. It goes back to the early monarchy and is probably the oldest continuous prose narrative in the Old Testament.

* 2 Sam 11:1: The story of David’s double crime shows how he, too, unlike other contemporary monarchs, was under the divine law, not above it, and how God draws good from evil, since it was Bathsheba’s son who would succeed David.

* 2 Sam 11:11: It was a religious law that soldiers should remain continent in time of war; cf. 1 Sam 21:4–5.

* 2 Sam 13:1: The first signs of dissension become visible.

* 2 Sam 16:22: Absalom’s action meant that he was supplanting his father in the kingship; cf. 3:7; 12:8.

* 2 Sam 20:10: Thus did Joab remove his last rival and remain in power till David’s death, in spite of the king’s dislike of him.

* 2 Sam 22:2–51: This song, probably inserted later, is very similar to Psalm 18.

* 2 Sam 24:1: God is here said to command the census, presumably on the general grounds of ascribing the king's policies to him, but in verse 10 David says he has sinned thereby, and in 1 Chron 21:1 the census is ascribed to Satan as an infringement of God's prerogatives.

THE FIRST BOOK OF KINGS

* The First and Second Books of the Kings (the Third and Fourth Books of the Kings): the period covered in these books extends from the death of David to after the fall of Jerusalem in the year 586 B.C. The main theme is the steady decline of Israel dragged down by the monarchy, and her punishment by God for the worship of false gods, introduced by Solomon and actively promoted by many of his successors, especially in the northern kingdom. Back to text.

* 1 Kings 1:1: The story continues from 2 Sam 20:26.

* 1 Kings 1:5: There was as yet no natural right of succession and David had already given the right to Solomon, a younger son; cf. verse 13.

* 1 Kings 3:1: Chapters 3–11 give the history of Solomon. The *Pharaoh* of 3:1 and 9:16 (?) was of the twenty-first dynasty, possibly Psusennes II.

* 1 Kings 3:5, *a dream:* A common means of divine communication, especially before the age of the prophets.

* 1 Kings 4:32, *proverbs*: Doubtless some of those of the book of Proverbs are to be ascribed to Solomon. The book of Wisdom however (called in Greek The Wisdom of Solomon), is ascribed to him only because of his reputation for wisdom. It was actually written in the first century B.C.

* 1 Kings 6:1: The temple was built on the high ground to the north of Ophel, David's city.

* 1 Kings 8:10, *cloud:* The visible sign of the presence of Yahweh taking possession of his sanctuary; later called the shekinah by the rabbis.

* 1 Kings 8:23–53: This eloquent prayer admirably sums up the relation of God to his people.

* 1 Kings 8:27: A reminder that Yahweh was very different from the gods of other nations, who dwelt in their temples.

* 1 Kings 9:3–9: God's response to Solomon's prayer.

* 1 Kings 10:1, *Sheba:* A kingdom in southwestern Arabia.

* 1 Kings 10:22, *ships of Tarshish:* i.e., ships that could sail to Tarshish (usually located in Spain). The word then came to be applied to ocean-

going vessels.

* 1 Kings 11:1–8: This account of Solomon's moral decline stresses the connection between apostasy and sexual excess—a theme often met with in the Old Testament.

* 1 Kings 11:14: Because of Solomon's idolatry, God raised up enemies, to the south (Edom), to the north (Damascus), and within the kingdom (Jeroboam).

* 1 Kings 12:1, *Shechem* was the old religious center of the northern tribes. The alliance between these and Judah was never very strong, even during the united monarchy.

* 1 Kings 12:28, *Behold your gods*: Jeroboam seems to have had no intention of introducing false gods. These were to be images of Yahweh. But in doing this he debased the whole idea of true worship and made it more like pagan religion, to which it was bound to lead in the end; cf. 16:31. Judah, with all its advantages of temple and dynasty, was no better at this time, but reforms were instituted at intervals.

* 1 Kings 16:24, *hill of Samaria:* One of the most splendid sites in the Middle East for a capital city. But even so, the northern kingdom never achieved stability.

* 1 Kings 17:1: With this description of the drought begins the prophetic career of Elijah, the great opponent of the nature religion that flourished in the northern kingdom and that Ahab and his Phoenician wife, Jezebel, were so active in promoting.

* 1 Kings 18:19, *prophets of Baal:* These had been brought from Phoenicia by Jezebel.

* 1 Kings 19:8, *Horeb:* i.e., Mount Sinai, where the law was given to Moses and God made a covenant with his people.

* 1 Kings 21:10: Two witnesses were required for a legal charge involving the death penalty; cf. Susanna and the elders; cf. Num 35:30; Deut 19:15; Dan 13:40; Mt 18:16.

* 1 Kings 21:29: God has mercy on the repentant king, as before in the case of David. But he does not say here that the dynasty will be preserved.

THE SECOND BOOK OF KINGS

* 2 Kings 2:9, *a double share:* The eldest son inherited a double share of his father's property; cf. Deut 21:17. Elisha regarded himself as the son and so asked for Elijah's spirit as his inheritance.

* 2 Kings 3:4–27: The Moabite Stone, or Stele of Mesha, in the Louvre, found in Trans-Jordan in 1868, describes the liberation of Moab from Israel, but understandably is silent about its subjection.

* 2 Kings 5:15: A forthright monotheism that not even an Israelite could improve on. However, Naaman realized that Yahweh had a special relation to Israel; cf. verse 17.

* 2 Kings 9:24: So was the sin of Ahab visited upon his son, according to the word of the Lord; cf. 1 Kings 21:29.

* 2 Kings 14:21, *Azariah:* Otherwise known as Uzziah; cf. 15:13; 2 Chron 26:1–23.

* 2 Kings 15:19, *Pul*: i.e., Tiglath-pileser III; cf. verse 29.

* 2 Kings 16:3: Human sacrifice to Moloch was practiced in Phoenicia.

* 2 Kings 17:7–18: A full explanation of how Israel had sinned and was punished accordingly.

* 2 Kings 17:24–41: Origin of the Samaritans, written by an orthodox Jew.

* 2 Kings 19:35: It is usually supposed that the Assyrians were struck by a virulent disease.

* 2 Kings 22:8, *book of the law:* Probably Deuteronomy. In Deut 12–26 may be seen details of Josiah's reform, especially as regards the centralization of worship. The book must have been hidden or lost during the reign of the wicked Manasseh.

THE FIRST BOOK OF THE CHRONICLES

* The First and Second Books of the Chronicles (the First and Second Paralipomenon): These books, written after the Exile, give a second account of the period of the kingship. Composed as they were during a time of religious revival, they aim at giving a more religious history of the period than is available in Samuel and Kings. The author's interest is mainly in Judah and in the worship in the temple. The kingdom of David is idealized and some developments that took place later are here situated in his reign. Back to text.

* 1 Chron 1:1: Much space is given to genealogies in Chronicles. Postexilic Judaism was greatly interested in these in its efforts to preserve the race.

* 21—29: In these chapters the Chronicler enlarges on the organization of divine worship and of the clergy charged with carrying it out. He records

the erection of a (permanent) altar to Yahweh on the site of the future temple and even describes David's preparation for the temple construction.

* 1 Chron 24:3: There were two chief priests in the time of David, namely, Zadok and Abiathar, descended from Eleazar and Ithamar respectively; cf. 1 Sam 22:20; 2 Sam 15:24. Later, in the time of Solomon, Zadok became sole high priest.

THE SECOND BOOK OF THE CHRONICLES

* 2 Chron 1:1: The Chronicler makes no mention of the rival claims of Adonijah and of his being put to death by Solomon; cf. 1 Kings 2:13–25. He concentrates on the favorable aspects of the reign and enlarges on the wisdom Solomon received from God.

* 2 Chron 6:21, *hear from heaven:* This phrase recurs like a refrain throughout this prayer, which seems to have been given a liturgical form.

* 2 Chron 7:1, *fire came down:* As it did for Elijah's sacrifice; cf. 1 Kings 18:38.

* 2 Chron 9:31: One might have expected something to be said on Solomon's decline in morals, but it is passed over in silence. By contrast, the similar failings of his son Rehoboam are underlined; cf. chapters 11–12.

* 2 Chron 18:12, *prophets:* Jeremiah says that false prophets usually proclaim what their hearers want them to say: "every one deals falsely . . . saying, 'Peace, peace,' when there is no peace" (Jer 6:13–14). It will be noticed that the Chronicler omits a large part of 2 Kings which is concerned with the northern kingdom. Elijah, for example, is mentioned only once, in 21:12.

* 2 Chron 30:1, *Passover:* This Passover is not mentioned in Kings. The celebration inspired the people to go out and destroy the illegal high places and altars.

* 2 Chron 33:11: There is no record of this captivity of Manasseh in Babylon or of his subsequent repentance, either in 2 Kings or in the Assyrian records, though he is known from the latter to have been a vassal of Assyria.

* 2 Chron 33:18, *prayer:* An apocryphal prayer of Manasseh is usually printed at the end of editions of the Vulgate Bible.

THE BOOK OF EZRA

* The Books of Ezra and Nehemiah (The First and Second Books of Esdras): These two books were originally one and were written probably by the same author as Chronicles. They deal with the century following the

return from the Exile, but it is by no means a complete history that they give. The author's main purpose is to describe the religious and political reorganization after the return, and to underline the workings of God's providence. There is some uncertainty as to the chronology and order of the events described. Two main sources, the memoirs of Ezra and those of Nehemiah, are here intermingled. Back to text.

* Ezra 1:2: The Persians, unlike the Babylonians, pursued a very liberal policy in matters of religion.

* Ezra 4:4: Understandably, the people who had occupied the land in the absence of the exiles now resented their return and, especially, the building of the temple.

* Ezra 5:1: Building is resumed nearly twenty years later, and the temple is completed in four years (515 B.C.)—but it was a mere shadow of Solomon's temple; cf. 3:12.

* Ezra 7:1: Fifty-seven years later, i.e., about 458 B.C., according to one view, Ezra the scribe came with other exiles from Babylonia to carry out a much-needed reform. The total number in this group was some 6,000 or 8,000 persons. Many commentators place Ezra's coming in the reign of Ar-ta-xerxes II, 398 B.C., and hence after Nehemiah.

* 9–10: Mixed marriages. Experience had shown that marriage with women of other races involved serious risk of idolatry; cf. Solomon, 1 Kings 11:1–8.

THE BOOK OF NEHEMIAH

* Some years after the arrival of Ezra (cf. Ezra 7), Nehemiah had himself appointed governor of Jerusalem by the Persian king and came to that city to build up its walls (445 B.C.). As before, the project was opposed by the surrounding peoples (cf. chapters 4 and 6), but this time the work was not interrupted. Back to text.

* Neh 8–10: As it was only thirteen years since the reform of Ezra, some scholars think that this passage belongs to the book of Ezra.

* Neh 8:8: The book was of course written in Hebrew, but the people, since their sojourn in Babylonia, now spoke Aramaic, and it had to be translated for them into that tongue.

THE BOOK OF TOBIT

* The Books of Tobit, Judith and Esther

These three books appear together in the Greek Bible, usually after the historical books. The complete Aramaic original of Tobit and the Hebrew of

Judith have not survived, and neither book was included in the Jewish canon at the end of the first century A.D. Existing as they did in the Greek Bible, they would have been used and recognized as Scripture by the first Christians. The Greek "Additions to Esther" were probably written two centuries after the Hebrew text. They were composed in Egypt and they exhibit a strictly Jewish doctrine. All three books have a literary form somewhat strange to the Western mind. They are, in effect, religious tales with the appearance of an historical narrative. They may have an historical basis, but the persons, places, events and dates are woven into the narrative in such a way as to have little resemblance to the actual historical record as we know it from other sources. It would seem, therefore, that the writers are intending, not to write history as we understand that term, but to use historical material to impart a religious message.

The Book of Tobit (The Book of Tobias)

The author relates the story of a family living among a pagan people yet trusting fully in God in spite of difficulties. Belief in one God is stressed; marriage between Jews is likewise emphasized and angels figure prominently in the narrative. The book has much to say, too, about the need for good works. It was written after the Exile at some time during the Persian period, though the story may be a good deal older than that. It shows signs of dependence on earlier writings such as the *Story of Ahikar,* a sixth-century work from Babylon. It also bears a likeness to Genesis in certain points, e.g., to his last injunctions to the family, the important role of angels, the son's search for a wife, and the care given to burial of the dead. It is interesting to note that fragments of the Hebrew and Aramaic texts have been found at Qumran, which favor the longer text of Codex Sinaiticus, the Old Latin and the Vulgate. Back to text.

* Tob 4:10, *charity:* i.e., almsgiving; cf. also verses 11 and 16.

* Tob 4:12, *immorality:* i.e., impurity, fornication.

* Tob 4:17, *place your bread:* The Greek verb means literally "pour out." The Latin, with its "your bread and your wine," preserves better the original text, cf. the *Story of Ahikar:* "Pour out your wine on the graves of the righteous and drink it not with evil men."

* Tob 12:9, *charity:* See note on 4:10.

THE BOOK OF JUDITH

* This is an account of the routing of an army and the freeing of the people of God through a stratagem devised and carried out by a woman (cf.

Esther). The story is strongly nationalist in sentiment, especially the victory song in chapter 16. The writer stresses that Judith's strength comes from God in response to her trust in him, and because she faithfully keeps all the prescriptions of the law. The Greek version of the book (the basis of this translation) was made from a Hebrew original, now lost. The Latin version was made from an Aramaic text, almost a paraphrase, which is not now extant and which apparently omitted about a fifth of the book. Back to text.

* Jud 8:1: The names in this genealogy differ in the various texts and versions.

* Jud 10:4: The remainder of this verse reads in the Vulgate (verse 4): " [4]And the Lord also gave her more beauty: because all this dressing–up did not proceed from sensuality, but from virtue: and therefore the Lord increased this her beauty, so that she appeared to all men's eyes incomparably lovely."

* Jud 13:20: Vulgate adds (verses 27–31): " [27]And Achior being called for came, and Judith said to him: The God of Israel, to whom you gave testimony, that he revenge himself of his enemies, he has cut off the head of all the unbelievers this night by my hand. [28]And that you may find that it is so, behold the head of Holofernes, who in the contempt of his pride despised the God of Israel, and threatened you with death, saying: When the people of Israel shall be taken, I will command your sides to be pierced with a sword. [29]Then Achior, seeing the head of Holofernes, being seized with a great fear he fell on his face upon the earth, and his soul swooned away. [30]But after he had recovered his spirits, he fell down at her feet, and reverenced her, and said: [31]Blessed are you by your God in every tabernacle of Jacob, for in every nation which shall hear your name, the God of Israel shall be magnified on occasion of you."

* Jud 15:9, *You are the exaltation of Jerusalem:* This passage is included in the office for feasts of the Blessed Virgin Mary, e.g., the little chapter for None on the Assumption, 15 August.

* Jud 16:25: Vulgate adds (verse 31): " [31]But the day of the festivity of this victory is received by the Hebrews in the number of holy days, and is religiously observed by the Jews from that time until this day."

THE BOOK OF ESTHER

* Set in the Persian capital Susa, this story relates how God saved his people from the hands of an enemy, this time in a foreign country. As in the

book of Judith, the deliverance is brought about through the instrumentality of a woman. The book gives details for the keeping of the feast of Purim in memory of this deliverance. Back to text.

* Esther 11:2: The disarrangement of the chapter and verse order is due to the insertion of the deuterocanonical portions in their logical place in the story of Esther, as narrated in the Greek version from which they are taken. They are printed in italics to enable the reader to recognize them at once.

In the old Vulgate these portions were placed by Jerome immediately after the Hebrew text of Esther, regardless of their logical position, because he himself did not regard them as canonical. Hence they came to be numbered 10:4—16:24. It has been thought best to leave the chapter and verse numbering unchanged in the present edition.

* Esther 15:1–16: This deuterocanonical passage is a later expansion of the Hebrew text 5:1–2, which is as follows: “On the third day Esther put on her royal robes and stood in the inner court of the king’s palace, opposite the king’s hall. The king was sitting on his royal throne inside the palace opposite the entrance to the palace; [2]and when the king saw Queen Esther standing in the court, she found favor in his sight and he held out to Esther the golden scepter that was in his hand. Then Esther approached and touched the top of the scepter.” Greek and Hebrew rejoin at verse 3.

THE BOOK OF JOB

* This book is one of the most interesting among the texts that make up the Wisdom literature of the Old Testament. It deals with a profound subject: the problem of the suffering of good men; and is written almost entirely in poetry. It is probably postexilic and its author is unknown.

The problem is clear enough. Material rewards and punishments are promised respectively for the observance or transgression of God’s law; cf. Lev 26; Deut 28. We see the application of this, in Judges and Kings, to the people of Israel. This is collective responsibility; and sometimes, of course, the good have to suffer because of the bad. But when it is a case of individual responsibility, as in Job, why should the good man suffer? Various solutions are proposed but none that satisfies entirely. As yet there is no clear belief in the afterlife with its rewards and punishments; still less is there anything approaching the revelation of the New Testament as exemplified in Christ’s life. Job knows he is innocent though suffering. Is God therefore unjust? He rejects the suggestion and submits himself to

God's power and mercy without receiving a final answer. In the end he is reinstated in his former state of affluence.

The speeches of Elihu (chapters 32–37) are a later insertion. These chapters can be removed without causing any break in the narrative. Elihu is not mentioned elsewhere in the book, nor does Job appear to take any notice of what he has said. The insertion seems to have been made in order to stress the value of suffering in bringing a man back to God. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF THE PSALMS

* The Psalter consists of 150 psalms or sacred hymns. In it we find poetical compositions of different kinds—hymns of praise, prayers for specific liturgical occasions, lamentations both of the individual and the nation, among others. There are psalms that express the deepest emotions of the human heart. They were used in, and many of them composed for, the temple worship. Some of them date back to King David, others were written after the Exile. Their composition thus covers a long period. They were gradually brought together in small collections and finally edited in one large collection arranged in five books. This became the hymnbook of the Second Temple.

The Christian Church took over the Psalter and used it following the example of Jesus himself. The Psalms have always been used extensively in the liturgy and in the dally office of the priest. In the early Church lay people became familiar with them, as St. Jerome tells us.

The numbering of the Psalms used here is that of the Hebrew Bible, which is, of course, followed in the Revised Standard Version. It varies somewhat from the Greek, which is followed by the Latin Vulgate and vernacular versions based on it. This alternative numbering is given in brackets. Psalms 9 and 10 in the Hebrew form Psalm 9 in the Vulgate. Psalms 114 and 115 in the Hebrew are counted as Psalm 113 in the Vulgate. Back to text.

* Ps 2:1 Together with Ps 110 a royal, Messianic psalm, often applied to Jesus as Messiah in the New Testament.

* Ps 8:1 A magnificent hymn to the glory of God as seen in creation and reflected in man.

* Ps 18:1 A slightly different form of this psalm is found in 2 Sam 22.

* Ps 22:1 This lamentation of the righteous man in his sufferings has profoundly influenced the Gospel passion story. See especially Mt 27:46.

* Ps 42:1 This and the following psalm were originally one, as can be seen from the refrain repeated three times.
* Ps 51:1 This psalm, known as the “Miserere,” is the one most used in the Liturgy of the Hours to express repentance for sin.
* Ps 68:1 This is one of the most ancient compositions in the Psalter and has been influenced by Canaanite motifs and representations.
* Ps 93:1 The first of several psalms which represent Yahweh as enthroned in heaven.
* Ps 104:1 A magnificent hymn of creation, it should be compared with Gen 1. It is remarkably similar to an Egyptian hymn to Aten, the sun god.
* Ps 110:1 See note on Ps 2.
* Ps 119:1 This great hymn of praise for the Torah, the law of God, is typical of the best Jewish piety after the Exile.
* Ps 120:1 The first of the “Songs of Ascents,” or “Gradual Psalms,” that is, those that were recited or sung during the journey to Jerusalem on the occasion of the great pilgrim feasts.
* Ps 137:1 This psalm breathes the spirit of sadness and homesickness of the Israelite in exile in Babylon.
* Ps 150:1 This exclamation of praise serves as the epilogue to the Psalter.

THE BOOK OF THE PROVERBS

The proverb or saying (*mashal*) was a typical form of expression in a society that depended to a large extent on oral tradition. Each saying expressed some important truth in pithy and memorable form. The proverbs contained in this book were, of course, regarded as divinely inspired teaching and had a correspondingly weighty authority. The book contains a number of collections of proverbs, two of which are ascribed to Solomon (10:1—22:16 and 25:1—29:27), but it is not likely that all the proverbs in these collections are in fact attributable to Solomon. It is probable that 10:1—22:16 forms the original nucleus of the book.

The general subject of the proverbs is the art of right living. Some points are dealt with in detail, for example, wisdom and folly, justice and injustice, and so on. They are not simply maxims of natural wisdom but presuppose a background of revealed religion and inculcate its principles. Religion is in fact regarded as the basis of all morality. The book was finally edited and put together after the Exile. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF ECCLESIASTES

The name is the Greek rendering of the Hebrew, Qoheleth, which means "one who convenes or speaks in an assembly." Hence the name: the Preacher. By a literary device the book is ascribed to Solomon, but in fact it was written after the Exile, probably in the third century B.C. There is no knowledge in the book of any idea of rewards and punishments after this life, thus much the same problem is met with here as in the book of Job. Why do the good suffer and the wicked flourish? Belief and experience do not harmonize. Ecclesiastes has to insist on God's goodness and power and providence even though experience seems at times to show the contrary. He has no solution to offer other than faith in God and trust that he will, in his own way and time, punish evil and reward good; cf. 3:17; 8:12–13. He constantly emphasizes the vanity of created things, which can never satisfy the heart of man. Thus he gives us something more than an unsolved problem and stimulates faith and trust in God in spite of appearances which might influence us to the contrary. Back to text.

THE SONG OF SOLOMON

The full title is "The Song of Songs Which Is Solomon's." But, as in the case of other books, it is ascribed to him because of his fame. It is a love song or collection of love songs written probably in the fifth century B.C. The Jews had some doubts as to its canonical character but finally included it in their canon of Scripture, and it has always been accepted by the Christian Church as inspired and canonical.

The interpretations of the book have been of great variety. For our purpose we may summarize them thus: (1) It is purely allegorical. For the Jews it represented the relationship between God and his chosen people Israel, which is often in the Old Testament described under the figure of a marriage. The Christian Fathers, of course, saw it as an allegory of Christ and his Church, describing the mystic union between the two; cf. Eph 5:21–33. (2) Others hold it to be a poem describing human love between bride and groom without seeking to identify actual historical persons. The writer's purpose was to extol married love and the sanctity of the marriage bond as instituted and blessed by God. There is support in the Old Testament for this view, e.g., in Proverbs and Sirach. (3) Others again, while admitting the above literal sense of the book, say that it is to be taken in the typical sense of the union of God with Israel, and of the union of Christ with his Church.

Catholics tend to adopt the first or third of these positions. Either way, the interpretation can be developed to include the relations between God and the individual soul, as is done by mystical writers, e.g., St. John of the Cross. The Song of Solomon is extensively used in the liturgy, particularly on feasts of the Blessed Virgin Mary and of Holy Women.

Although this is the one book of the Bible where God is never mentioned by name, its presence in the Bible indicates the sanctity of human love. Back to text.

THE WISDOM OF SOLOMON

The book describes the part that Wisdom plays in the life and destiny of men and how we should acquire it, says much about the divine Wisdom, and, in the latter part of the book, relates how the chosen people were guided thereby throughout their history. At times the book proclaims truths not exactly in harmony with beliefs then current, e.g., that suffering is not necessarily the consequence of sin. The book was written in Greek, probably in the first century B.C. Its author is unknown. It is ascribed to Solomon according to a widespread practice of the time of adopting the name of a famous man in antiquity to "father" one's work. Thus David was known to have written psalms and hence many subsequent psalms were ascribed to him. Moses enacted laws and thus many subsequent laws were ascribed to him which at best could be said to be only indirectly connected with the great lawgiver. So here, Solomon was the "wise man"—and hence it was natural to attribute the book to him. Back to text.

* Wis 1:5, a *holy and disciplined spirit:* Literally, "a holy spirit of discipline." Verse 6 seems to suggest here a personification of the Holy Spirit; cf. also verse 7: *the Spirit of the Lord.*

* Wis 5:13: Vulgate adds (verse 14): "[14]Such things as these the sinners said in hell."

* Wis 6:6, *tested:* The meaning seems rather to be "tormented" and to refer to punishment.

* Wis 11:26, *Lord who love the living:* Vulgate has "souls" for "living." The Greek word could mean either.

THE BOOK OF SIRACH

The Book of Sirach (Ecclesiasticus) belongs to the Wisdom literature and was written by Ben Sira, a "sage of Israel," in the early second century B.C. It was originally composed in Hebrew, as we learn from the Prologue, and translated into Greek some fifty years later by his grandson. During these

fifty years there had been a violent persecution of the Jews by the Seleucid kings in order to force them to adopt Greek religion and culture. The beginnings of this were already apparent in the time of Ben Sira, and it was to counteract such influences that his book was written. It is full of traditional Jewish wisdom and morals; indeed, full of worldly wisdom and written by one with wide experience of life. He re-emphasizes the traditional truths, but manages to do this in an interesting way and sometimes even from a new angle, e.g., his words on death (40:2; 41:2).

Sirach was included in the Greek Bible but not in the later Jewish canon. The Hebrew text was known to Jerome but later disappeared and was rediscovered, though not complete, only at the end of the nineteenth century in Cairo. Further fragments have been found recently in Palestine.

The Church accepted the book as canonical, but it was the Greek text she accepted. The name Ecclesiasticus was given to it in its Old Latin version—a name which appears to date from the time of St. Cyprian. St. Jerome did not translate the book or revise the Old Latin, so the text is substantially as he found it. It is a version made from the Greek, but a Greek text notably different from the one we use, chiefly in the quantity of additional material. However, these additions do not add anything substantially new to the book except, perhaps, the spirit in which they are written. The version has been described as "a Pharisaic recension of the original work of Ben Sira." Back to text.

THE BOOK OF THE PROPHET ISAIAH

The Books of Prophecy

In ancient times there were prophets of many different religions, men who claimed to speak in the name of their gods; and not infrequently they existed in large groups. Thus Elijah had to confront no less than 450 prophets of Baal on the occasion of the contest on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18). There were similar groups of prophets who spoke in the name of Yahweh. These prophets experienced ecstasies and trances often induced by the playing of music (1 Sam 10:5), and seem to have been organized into communities (2 Kings 2:3–18).

The prophets, however, whom we know by name and whose actions are recorded in the Bible, were very different from these and their influence on Israel was much more profound. So far from their seeking prophecy as a profession, it was imposed on them by God and they could not refuse (Jer 1:9; Amos 3:8). So far from their trying by fair words to please their

hearers, they often had to announce approaching disaster as punishment for sin. Not only their words, their whole life was given up to the ministry, and they had to lead a life of great penance and sacrifice often ending in violent death. The prophet received an inner, wordless message, which he was then compelled to communicate, sometimes in lyric poetry, sometimes in prose, often making use of parables, allegories, and symbolic actions. When disaster had fallen on the nation, then the role of the prophet changed from one of threat to one of consolation (Is 40ff.). It was in such times as these that many Messianic prophecies were uttered, foretelling the coming of God's kingdom in "the last days" heralded by God's anointed or "messiah." The character and mission of Christ are vividly portrayed in Isaiah and even his sufferings are there described, though it does not follow that those who first heard the prophecies understood all that was being said. Many prophecies were fully understood only when they came to pass.

THE BOOK OF THE PROPHET ISAIAH

Isaiah, the greatest of all the prophets, lived at a critical time in Israel's history. The very existence of the people was threatened by the king of Assyria in the latter part of the eighth century B.C. The well-known and beautiful Immanuel prophecies (chapters 6–12) were uttered on occasions of great national danger when Judah was ruled by an unworthy king—Ahaz. Under his successor, Hezekiah, a good and prudent king, Isaiah, who was himself of noble birth, occupied a position of influence in promoting religious reform, and many of his prophecies are to be ascribed to this period. He was by now a national figure with a large following. He appears last of all in the great crisis of 701 B.C. when, as he had promised, Jerusalem was saved from destruction by the Assyrians.

His prophecies are distinguished both for their poetical quality and for the elevation of their thought. The monotheism of Isaiah is declared in eloquent terms. Likewise, his Messianic predictions attain a clarity that has induced some to give him the title of "evangelist." The second part of the book (chapters 40–55), quite different from the first and perhaps even more sublime, is generally held now not to be by Isaiah himself but by a later prophet writing at the time of the Exile, doubtless a member of the Isaian school and following in his tradition. These chapters are remarkable for the words of comfort and encouragement they contain and perhaps even more for the remarkable "Servant Songs," prophecies about the Messiah to come,

foretelling his sufferings. The remaining chapters (56–66) contain a varied selection of prophecies of different dates. Back to text.

* Is 2:2–4: Note the universalism of this prophecy.

* Is 5:1–7: This moving allegory may be compared with similar passages in the New Testament, e.g., Mt 21:33–41; Jn 15:1–2.

* Is 6:1–13: This vision stresses the solemnity of the prophet's calling. The "*Holy, holy, holy"* is fittingly included in the Mass. The vision also serves to introduce the Immanuel prophecies.

* Is 7:14, *virgin* or *young woman:* The Hebrew word *'almah* is not explicit. The Greek translates this as *parthenos,* "virgin," and may be regarded as a witness to later Jewish tradition as to the meaning of the prophecy. The virginal conception is, of course, unequivocally stated in the Gospel where this prophecy is quoted (Mt 1:23; cf. also Lk 1:35).

* Is 9:6: Passage selected for the Introit of the Mass of Christmas Day, showing that the Church regards these words as being fulfilled in Jesus Christ.

* Is 11:1–3: cf. 61:1–2 and Lk 4:18–19.

* Is 11:2: The enumeration of the "gifts of the Holy Spirit" is taken from this passage.

* Is 40:1: Here begins the "Book of the Consolation of Israel," as it has been beautifully called. It was written to comfort and console the people in their exile in Babylonia.

* Is 42:1–4: The "Servant of Yahweh" is here introduced. This and three other prophecies (49:1–6; 50:4–9; 52:13—53:12) depict the Messiah in a new light, giving details of his meekness and suffering.

* Is 53:4–6: The doctrine of vicarious atonement is the unique characteristic of this prophecy. We find it in the New Testament in all its fulness.

* 56 to the end: These prophecies were probably uttered in the difficult days of the return from exile, about the year 538 B.C.

* Is 61:1–4: cf. Lk 4:18–19.

THE BOOK OF JEREMIAH

* Jeremiah, sometimes called a prophet of doom, lived at the most tragic period of Israel's history, during which Jerusalem was destroyed by Nebuchadrezzar and the people were carried off into captivity. He was of a priestly family and he makes it clear in his book that he obeyed God's call to prophesy most reluctantly. It was his task, under the circumstances, to

preach repentance and prophesy destruction if repentance was not forthcoming. But his words fell on deaf ears. In so far as the people heard at all, it was only to resent what he said and make him suffer for it. As the prophet was of a specially sensitive and affectionate nature, his sufferings were all the more acute.

He did not always prophesy doom. Thus in 31:31–34, he foretells the new covenant in terms that remind us of passages in the prophet Isaiah. His words may not have had much effect during his lifetime but after his death his influence was considerable, as was the case with other prophets also; cf. Mt 23:29–30. Not all the prophecies in the book are from Jeremiah himself but some have been inserted later. An important feature of the book is the quantity of biographical material, which tells us a great deal about the prophet.Back to text.

* Jer 1:6: Typically, Jeremiah is reluctant to accept an office for which he feels himself ill suited, and which, he foresees, can bring nothing but suffering and disappointment.

* Jer 3:16: The ark must have been destroyed at the same time as the temple in 586 B.C. In the Messianic times the presence of the Lord will not be restricted to the ark of the covenant; cf. Rev 21:22.

* Jer 7:4: Trust in the temple's presence without true service of God and observance of his commands is vain, just as earlier a similar trust in the presence of the ark was fruitless without moral observance; 1 Sam 4:3.

* Jer 8:7: cf. Is 1:3.

* Jer 9:23–24: The basis of true religion.

* Jer 13:1–11: Note here and elsewhere the use of symbolic action throughout Jeremiah's ministry.

* Jer 30:8: The new covenant and the restoration.

* Jer 31:15: Quoted by Matthew and applied to the Holy Innocents (Mt 2:18).

* Jer 31:31–34: The new covenant; cf. Mt 26:28.

* Jer 33:15: cf. Is 11:1: "a shoot from the stump of Jesse."

* Jer 35:1 This chapter is our chief source of information about the little-known sect of Rechabites; cf. 2 Kings 10:15–16, 23. They obeyed what they felt to be a call to serve God in the wilderness and desert places. The ancient nomad life during the Exodus was always looked back to as the time of the greatest fidelity to God.

* Jer 52:1 Historical supplement which recapitulates and enlarges on 2 Kings 24:18—25:30. Cf.Is 36–39, which was added in the same way.

THE LAMENTATIONS OF JEREMIAH

* This book is traditionally ascribed to Jeremiah but is probably not all by him. It seems rather to have been composed by more than one author, though at about the same period of the siege and exile. The poems, written in the rhythm known as *qinah*, were probably composed for the liturgical services that continued to be held on the site of the temple. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF BARUCH

* This book, one of the deuterocanonical books, is not extant in Hebrew and is placed here after Lamentations in the Latin Vulgate. It is said to have been composed by Baruch at Babylon during the Exile, but in fact the evidence indicates rather that some of it was composed about the second or even first century B.C. The material may well have been composed at different periods, and the final editing have taken place toward the time of Christ. The particular value of the book is that it gives an insight into Jewish life in the Dispersion. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF EZEKIEL

* The beginning of Ezekiel's ministry overlapped the end of that of Jeremiah and the prophet is concerned with the same evils. But his style and matter are very different. Ezekiel was a priest and mainly concerned with the temple worship and the observances of the law. His description of the future temple should be compared with that in Rev 21. Ezekiel performs a great variety of symbolic actions—as did Jeremiah on a smaller scale. Ezekiel's visions make one think of apocalyptic writing, e.g., Daniel and Revelation. He does not enlarge greatly on Messianic themes. He speaks of a new covenant (16:60) and, like Jeremiah, of personal responsibility (chapter 18). Above all, he insists on the need for interior renewal, and thus prepares the way for the teaching of Christ. Back to text.

* Ezek 1:5, *four living creatures:* The description recalls the Assyrian *karibu*: statues of animals with human heads guarding the palace at Nineveh. Here these creatures are pressed into the service of Yahweh. They are met again in Rev 4:6–8. The point of the vision is that Yahweh is not tied to Jerusalem and could follow his people into exile.

* Ezek 1:23: cf. the cherubim over the ark (Ex 25:20–22; 1 Sam 4:4).

* Ezek 1:28, *the glory of the Lord*: The luminous cloud, or shekinah (Ex 24:16), that normally dwelt in the temple.

* Ezek 8:14, *weeping for Tammuz:* A vegetation god known as Adonis to the Phoenicians. He was supposed to die in the summer and come to life again in the spring. Women wept at the time of his departure to the underworld.

* Ezek 14:12–23: The Lord stresses individual responsibility rather than collective responsibility. It had been taken for granted that some just men would have to suffer in a group or city with the guilty majority.

* Ezek 14:14, *Daniel:* It is possible that this refers to Danel, an ancient Phoenician sage known to us from the Ras Shamra literature. It is unlikely that Ezekiel would have been speaking of Daniel the prophet as the other names in this passage are both of more ancient personages. Moreover, the spelling of the name in the book of Ezekiel is different from the spelling used in the book of Daniel.

* Ezek 17:2–24: The Messiah, a shoot from the stump of Jesse. Cf. Is 11:1, and also the parable of the mustard seed (Mt 13:31–32).

* Ezek 26: The city of Tyre, in those days an island and one of the richest cities in the East, was regarded as impregnable from the landward side. In this instance the siege lasted thirteen years but remained indecisive, as Nebuchadnezzar had no fleet. We must, therefore, regard the prophet's language here as rhetorical rather than historical; cf. 29:18.

* Ezek 34:2, *shepherds of Israel:* cf. Jn 10:1–30.

* Ezek 34:23–31: The Messiah and his kingdom.

* Ezek 37:1, *full of bones:* This vision foretells the restoration of Israel after the Exile (verse 12). It has sometimes been thought, wrongly, to foretell the resurrection of the body.

* Ezek 38–39: Gog and Magog. Gog—an obscure name probably meaning "darkness"—here represents the forces of evil. He is destroyed by Yahweh. Magog probably means no more than "land of Gog." The names appear to be used here as ciphers for Nebuchadnezzar and Babylon.

* Ezek 40–48. In these chapters Ezekiel describes the new temple and its worship. The passage is not meant to be taken historically and, in fact, the later builders of the temple made no attempt to take it literally. The prophet is referring to the Messianic times in symbolic language.

THE BOOK OF DANIEL

* The book is composed of two distinct parts. In the first, there are stories about Daniel in the time of the Babylonian Empire; in the second, there are a number of apocalyptic visions ascribed to Daniel and foretelling the

future. The stories of the first part may be based on original material dating from the time of Daniel but must have been written down later, as they betray an unfamiliarity with the history of the period. Likewise, the visions of the second part are predominantly concerned with the later Greek Empire and it is unlikely that they were composed before that time. Their literary form, too, corresponds to the apocalyptic style of literature common in the second century B.C. The Greek version has some portions not in the Hebrew or Aramaic and these are accepted as canonical by the Catholic Church. They are: The Prayer of Azariah and the Song of the Three Young Men (3:*1–68*); Susanna (chapter 13); Bel and the Dragon (chapter 14). In the rest of the book there are some parts written in Aramaic, thus suggesting a rather late date.

In the first part of the book, the main purpose is to exalt the God of Israel over the gods of the pagans through the experiences of the prophet Daniel. In the second part, the aim is equally to exalt the God of Israel, but this time it is done through a series of visions in which many prophecies are made—the chief of which is the seventy weeks of years until the coming of the Messiah (9:24). The author aims at sustaining the faith of the people of God during difficult times culminating in the persecution of Antiochus Epiphanes. Back to text.

* Dan 1:8, *would not defile himself:* When the Greek persecution broke out, the king tried to get the Jews to break their laws about food and drink, and such breaches of the law were taken to be apostasy; cf. 2 Mac 6:18—7:42.

* Dan 3:23: After this verse the section (sixty-eight verses) printed in italics is contained only in the Greek. It is here translated from Theodotion's version. Concordance of verse numberings:

RSV	Vulgate
1–28	24–51
29–30	52
31	53
32	55
33	54
34	56
35	57
36	59
37	58

38–45 60–67
46 68–69
47 71
48 72
49–50 70
51–68 73–90

* Dan 3:68: The reader will notice that the roman figures used for the remaining verses of this chapter take up again the numbering of the protocanonical text. Verses 24–30 are numbered 91–97 in the Greek and Vulgate; they are written in Aramaic, not Hebrew.

* Dan 4:1–3: These verses correspond to 3:31–33 in the Aramaic and to 3:98–100 in the Greek and Vulgate. The chapter is considerably longer in the Greek than in the Aramaic.

* Dan 4:8, *Belteshazzar*: The name given to Daniel means “May Bel protect his life.”

* Dan 4:13, a *watcher, a holy one*: An angel, so called because he is ever watchful to serve God. In Ezek 1:18 the wheels representing angels are said to be full of eyes.

* Dan 5:1, *Belshazzar*: He was the son of Nabonidus and was never in fact king.

* Dan 5:31, *Darius the Mede*: Nothing is known in history of this person. The Persians, moreover, had already conquered the Medes before taking Babylon.

* Dan 7:8, *another horn, a little one*: Antiochus Epiphanes, who originally was of no importance.

* Dan 7:13, a *son of man*: The same title with which God addressed Ezekiel. Here it means someone who is more than human.

* Dan 9:24–27: Prophecy of the seventy weeks. The prophecy, made to encourage the Jews in time of persecution, looks to the future Messianic age in the time of the end; cf. 12:9. The seventy weeks are seventy seven-year periods, i.e., 490 years. But we can hardly take it as an exact historical period. Its immediate application seems to be to the period 170–163 B.C., i.e., from the beginning of the persecution of the Jews by Antiochus Epiphanes to the purification of the temple and the death of Antiochus.

* Dan 10–12: Summary of the history of the Persian and Greek periods down to Antiochus Epiphanes and thence to the time of the end.

* Dan 13:1: The story of Susanna, here translated from the Greek of Theodotion, is accepted by the Catholic Church as canonical Scripture and placed among the deuterocanonical writings. It is prefixed to the book of Daniel in the Septuagint Greek, but in the Vulgate Latin it is placed here as chapter 13.

* Dan 14:1: Bel and the Dragon. These stories, here translated from the Greek of Theodotion, are added at the end of Daniel by both Greek and Vulgate. The latter treats the appendix as chapter 14, but attaches verse 1 to the preceding chapter as 13:65.

The Books of the Minor Prophets

These twelve are grouped together both in the Hebrew and in the Greek. The only reason for this seems to be that the books happen to be short. They are not "minor" in any other way; their religious value is great. They do not belong to any one historical period, and they range from Amos (eighth century B.C.) to Malachi, Joel, Obadiah, and Jonah (fifth to fourth century B.C.). They are here arranged according to their traditional order in the Hebrew, which is not the same as their historical order. The Latin Vulgate also follows the order of the Hebrew.

THE BOOK OF HOSEA

* Hosea (Osee) preached and prophesied during the century—the eighth—that saw the decline and final destruction of the northern kingdom. It was a period of both moral and material dissolution, and it is this that gives his prophecy its peculiar characteristics. Hosea seems to take occasion of his own unhappy marriage to draw a parallel between it and the relationship between God and his unfaithful spouse Israel. He attacks passionately the moral evils and the injustice of the society in which he lives. Above all, he condemns the idolatry rampant everywhere, as well as the debased Yahweh worship. Israel will be punished, but after repentance the people will be welcomed back to their God. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF JOEL

* Joel prophesied about four centuries later than Hosea, during the postexilic period. He foretells a plague of locusts as punishment and speaks threateningly of the "day of the LORD"; but then at once declares the Lord to be merciful and kind to those who repent. Toward the end of chapter 2 the style becomes apocalyptic and he speaks of the outpouring of the Spirit upon the people in the Messianic age. This was fulfilled (Acts 2:16–21) at Pentecost. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF AMOS

* Amos was a shepherd of Judah called suddenly by God to denounce social corruption and injustice in the northern kingdom during the reign of Jeroboam II (eighth century B.C.). It was a time of great material luxury and worldly splendor, and the pastoral origins of the prophet contrasted strongly with the sophisticated decadence which, together with the people's infidelity, he denounced. He foretells the "day of the LORD," a time of punishment for men's sins, but holds out a hope of God's mercy to "the remnant of Joseph" (5:15). Some of the prophecies are probably of a later age. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF OBADIAH

* The book of Obadiah (Abdias) is so short that it is difficult to be certain of its date and character. It is a tirade against the people of Edom, who are told not to exult over the misfortune of Jerusalem, for they shall be utterly destroyed, while a remnant from Israel shall survive. It seems to apply to the situation of the postexilic period when the surrounding nations, including Edom, had partly occupied the vacant territory of Judah. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF JONAH

* The Book of Jonah (Jonas) is set in the reign of Jeroboam II (eighth century B.C.), but the book was probably written long after the Exile. This suggests that it is not meant to be taken historically, although the central figure, Jonah, is mentioned in 2 Kings 14:25 and appears to have been a well-known prophet of the time. In this story the writer, making use of many improbable details, teaches that God is merciful even in his punishments, if only his people will repent; and so far from being the God of Israel alone, he is prepared to extend his mercy to others, provided they possess or acquire the necessary dispositions of heart. Our Lord himself quotes the conversion of the Ninevites and the three days Jonah spent inside the great fish (Mt 12:38–41), but this is not a testimony to its historical character. He is concerned rather with its teaching. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF MICAH

* Micah lived and prophesied at about the same time as Isaiah, in the kingdom of Judah. Like his contemporaries, he denounces the evils of his age, which he contrasts dramatically with the requirements of God: "to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly" with God (6:8). He foretells God's punishments, even the fall of Jerusalem (3:12). At the same

time he prophesies, like Isaiah, that a remnant shall be saved (chapters 4–5) and speaks of the Messiah to come (5:2). Back to text.

THE BOOK OF NAHUM

* The opening words of the Book of Nahum announce the central theme —the coming destruction of Nineveh, the great oppressor of God's people. The passion with which this lyric poetry is imbued is explained by the tyranny endured for so long by Israel. But the deliverance announced will not, unfortunately, be of long duration. The fall of Nineveh (612 B.C.) will be followed by the fall of Jerusalem, but that is not part of the prophet's message. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF HABAKKUK

* There is not much evidence for the date of the Book of Habakkuk (Habacuc), but it is likely that the prophet is speaking against the Chaldeans under Nebuchadnezzar, who destroyed Jerusalem in 586 B.C. The book starts with a dialogue between the prophet and God—the prophet complaining, and the Lord explaining and foretelling the coming destruction of the oppressor. All this took place probably before the fall of Jerusalem. Habakkuk has some originality; he asks God to explain his thought: for example, why does he punish his erring people by a nation more wicked than itself? And hence, why does wickedness seem to triumph? This is the problem found all through the Old Testament. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF ZEPHANIAH

* Zephaniah (Sophonias) prophesied shortly before the religious reform of Josiah, i.e., about the year 630 B.C., and he proclaims in clarion tones the "day of the LORD," when his people will be crushed by their enemies because of their sins; cf. Amos. The words of Zephaniah (1:15) remind one of the *Dies irae*, which seems to have drawn its imagery from here. The prophet foretells punishment not only for Judah but also for the nations round about (2:4–15). Then, after more threats against Jerusalem (3:1–8), he utters consolations (3:9–20): the people will be restored, but chastened and humble. The reform of Josiah was too short-lived to affect the results of these prophecies—the Exile and the return followed within the century. Back to text.

THE BOOK OF HAGGAI

* Haggai (Aggeus) is the first of the postexilic prophets and differs considerably from the earlier. No longer do we read threats of punishment

for sin or words of consolation. The people need to be helped in their work of restoration and encouraged to persevere. Haggai first insists that the temple must be built before they think of anything else. This is to be the focal point of their life, as it was in the past, and they cannot hope for any prosperity without it. In spite of its humble appearance, the Spirit of God will rest upon it and the "latter splendor of this house shall be greater than the former, says the LORD of hosts" (2:9). Back to text.

THE BOOK OF ZECHARIAH

* Zechariah (Zacharias) prophesied at the same time as Haggai, about 520 B.C. and, like him, exhorted the people to press on with the building of the temple, but he goes on to develop the plans for the national restoration. He speaks in terms of a Messianic era in which the priesthood is supreme but the royal prerogatives are possessed by "the Branch" (6:12), a Messianic term for Zerubbabel. Chapters 1–8 relate a series of visions and are apocalyptic in tone. The second part (chapters 9–14) is quite different, and consists of a collection of prophecies dating from the fourth century and edited later during the Greek period. These are chiefly noteworthy for the Messianic passages in them, especially 9:9, fulfilled on Palm Sunday, and 12:10: "when they look on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn." Back to text.

THE BOOK OF MALACHI

The name Malachi (Malachias) merely means "my messenger," and the book is probably anonymous. Its contents suggest that the historical context is the period of Ezra and Nehemiah. The theme is the love of God for his people in spite of their backsliding. Both priests and people are guilty of not offering a clean sacrifice—and in 1:11 is the prophecy of the universal sacrifice, relating evidently to Messianic times. The prophet also denounces marriages with Gentiles and the practice of divorce. He goes on to proclaim the "day of the LORD," "great and terrible." Like many prophets, he does not distinguish between the first and second coming. Back to text.

The First and Second Books of the Maccabees

1 Maccabees deals with the history of the Jews in Palestine during the forty years from the accession of the Syrian king Antiochus Epiphanes to the death of Simon in 134 B.C. It was a life–and-death struggle between the Jews and the Syrians who wanted to impose Greek religion and culture on them. The book recounts the heroic deeds of the three great leaders, Judas Maccabeus and his brothers Jonathan and Simon, who were in turn at the

head of the Jewish people until death overtook them. It was written with a strong religious purpose, and the high point is reached with a description of the rededication of the temple. Originally written in Hebrew about the year 100 B.C. the book now exists only in a Greek translation.

2 Maccabees is quite different. It is not a continuation of 1 Maccabees but concentrates on the period of about fifteen years covered by 1 Maccabees, chapters 1–7. It aims at bringing out even more strongly the religious lessons of the time, and the story is written in a way that is more like a sermon than a history. The historical facts are arranged to suit the religious purpose of the book. Several passages in the work are well known in reference to particular doctrines, e.g., the resurrection of the body (7:9, 11; 14:46); rewards and punishments after death (6:26); prayers for the dead (12:42–45); the intercession of the saints (15:12–16). Back to text.

THE FIRST BOOK OF THE MACCABEES

* 1 Mac 4:29: Vulgate has “Judea” for *Idumea* and “Beth-horon” for *Beth-zur.*

* 1 Mac 5:35: Vulgate reads “Maspha” (i.e., Mizpah) for *Alema;* cf. note **b**.

* 1 Mac 5:66, 68: Vulgate has “aliens” and “strangers” for *Philistines,* and “Samaria” for *Marisa;* cf. note **c**.

* 1 Mac 9:37: Vulgate reads “Madaba” (i.e., Medeba, as in verse 36) for *Nadabath.*

THE SECOND BOOK OF THE MACCABEES

* 2 Mac 4:29: Vulgate reads: “And Menelaus was removed from the priesthood, Lysimachus his brother succeeding: and Sostratus was made governor of the Cyprians.”

* 2 Mac 4:34, *put him out of the way:* Vulgate has “slew him.”

* 2 Mac 4:40, *Auranus:* Vulgate has “Tyrannus.”

* 2 Mac 7:9, *to an everlasting renewal of life:* Vulgate has: “in the resurrection of eternal life.”

* 2 Mac 12:45: Vulgate has (verses 45–46): “[45]And because he considered that they who had fallen asleep with godliness had great grace laid up for them. [46]It is therefore a holy and wholesome thought to pray for the dead, that they may be loosed from sins.”

New Testament

Matthew

* Mt 1:1: The genealogy is given to show that Jesus had the descent required for Messiahship, i.e., from Abraham and, in particular, from David the King.

* Mt 1:16: Joseph's, not Mary's, descent is given here, as the Jews did not usually reckon descent through the mother. Joseph was the legal and presumed father, and it was this fact that conferred rights of inheritance, in this case, the fulfilment of the Messianic promises.

* Mt 1:25: This means only that Joseph had nothing to do with the conception of Jesus. It implies nothing as to what happened afterward.

* Mt 3:2: *Repent* implies an internal change of heart.

* Mt 3:6: Not a Christian baptism but a preparation for it.

* Mt 3:15: Though without sin, Jesus wished to be baptized by John, as this was the final preparation for his mission as Messiah.

* Mt 5:17: Jesus came to bring the old law to its natural fulfilment in the new, while discarding what had become obsolete; cf. Jn 4:21.

* Mt 5:29: An exaggeration to emphasize the need to avoid occasions of sin.

* Mt 5:32, *unchastity*: The Greek word used here appears to refer to marriages that were not legally marriages because they were either within the forbidden degrees of consanguinity (Lev 18:6–16) or contracted with a Gentile. The phrase *except on the ground of unchastity* does not occur in the parallel passage in Lk 16:18. See also Mt 19:9 (Mk 10:11–12), and especially 1 Cor 7:10–11, which shows that the prohibition is unconditional.

* Mt 6:6: This does not, of course, exclude public worship but ostentatious prayer.

* Mt 6:24, *mammon*: i.e., riches.

* Mt 8:3: The miracles of Jesus were never performed to amaze people and shock them into belief. They were worked with a view to a real strengthening of faith in the recipient or beholder, from whom the proper dispositions were required.

* Mt 8:29, *before the time*: Before the day of judgment the demons are permitted by God to tempt men and even to possess them.

* Mt 10:5: The gospel, the Messianic salvation, had first to be preached and offered to the chosen people, Israel. Later it would be offered to the Gentiles.

* Mt 11:3: The Baptist expected more obvious signs of the Messiah. By quoting the prophet Isaiah, Jesus showed that he was indeed inaugurating

the Messianic kingdom—but by doing good rather than by glorious manifestations or sudden punishments.

* Mt 11:27: This shows a profound relationship between the Son and the Father, far superior to adoptive sonship.

* Mt 12:14: The Pharisees regarded healing as work and so forbade it on the sabbath.

* Mt 12:24, *Beel-zebul*: Name of a Canaanite god meaning "the Prince-god." The Jews interpreted this name as "Prince of demons," because for them all false gods were demons. The form "Beel-zebub" is a contemptuous adaptation meaning "Lord of the flies."

* Mt 12:31: To attribute to the devil the works of the Holy Spirit seems to imply a hardness of heart that precludes repentance.

* Mt 12:46, *brethren*: The Greek word or its Semitic equivalent was used for varying degrees of blood relationship; cf. Gen 14:14; 29:12; Lev 10:4.

* Mt 12:48: Jesus puts the work of salvation before family relationships. It is not said, however, that he refused to see them.

* Mt 13:12: To those well-disposed Jews who have made good use of the old covenant will now be given the perfection of the new. On the other hand, from those who have rejected God's advances will now be taken away even that which they have, because the old covenant is passing away.

* Mt 13:52: This is Matthew's ideal: that the learned Jew should become the disciple of Jesus and so add the riches of the new covenant to those of the old, which he already possesses; cf. verse 12.

* Mt 13:55: See note on Mt 12:46.

* Mt 14:33: Their realization of his Godhead was the prelude to Peter's confession of faith at Caesarea Philippi (Mt 16:16).

* Mt 15:5: By dedicating his property to God, i.e., to the temple, a man could avoid having to help his parents, without actually giving up what he had. The scribes held such a vow to be valid without necessarily approving it.

* Mt 15:24: See note on Mt 10:5.

* Mt 16:14: The title of prophet had a Messianic significance because the gift of prophecy, which had been extinct since Malachi, was expected to return at the beginning of the Messianic era, especially by an outpouring of the Spirit as foretold by the prophet Joel and as realized in Acts 2:16.

* Mt 16:16: The context shows that Peter recognizes the sonship of Jesus as divine and not adoptive like ours. Mark and Luke in the parallel passages

mention only the confession of the Messiahship.

* Mt 16:18: The name “Peter” comes from the Greek word for “rock.” Jesus makes him the foundation on which the church is to be built. The word “church” means “assembly” or “society” of believers. The Hebrew equivalent is used in the Old Testament to indicate the chosen people. In applying it to the church, Jesus shows it to be the Messianic community foretold by the prophets.

* Mt 16:19, *the kingdom of heaven*: Peter has the key to the gates of the city of God. This power is exercised through the church. “Binding” and “loosing” are rabbinic terms referring to excommunication, then later to forbidding or allowing something. Not only can Peter admit to the kingdom; he also has power to make authoritative decisions in matters of faith or morals.

* Mt 16:26, *life* (both times): A play on the word “life”—natural and supernatural; cf. Mk 8:35–36.

* Mt 17:4: Peter thought the glorious Messianic kingdom had come. In fact, Jesus allowed this glimpse of his glory to strengthen them for the coming passion.

* Mt 18:9: Gehenna (see footnote **b**) was the name of a valley south of Jerusalem where human sacrifice had once been practiced; cf. 2 Chron 33:6. Later it became a cursed place and a refuse dump, and the name came to symbolize the Christian place of punishment.

* Mt 18:18: To the other apostles is given a share in the authority given to Peter.

* Mt 19:9: This appears to refer to the case in Mt 5:32, though the Greek word for “except” is different.

* Mt 19:11–12: Jesus means that a life of continence is to be chosen only by those who are called to it for the sake of the kingdom of God.

* Mt 21:9: The crowd openly recognizes Jesus as the Messiah and he allows it for the first time.

* Mt 21:23: They object to the assumption of authority implicit in the manner of his entry into the city and in his expulsion of the sellers from the temple.

* Mt 21:33–44: This parable is really an allegory in which almost every detail represents something in God’s dealings with Israel.

* Mt 22:11: The wedding garment represents the dispositions necessary for admission to the kingdom.

* Mt 23:5, *phylacteries*: Little leather boxes containing, on a very small scroll, the principal words of the law; cf. Deut 6:4–9. Taking the command literally, they fastened these to their arms and their foreheads.

* Mt 23:9: i.e., “Do not use the title without reference to God’s universal fatherhood.” He cannot mean that the title is never to be used by a son to his father.

* Mt 24:1—25:46: The “Eschatological Discourse,” as it is called, deals with the fall of Jerusalem and the end of the world. The two themes seem to be inextricably intermingled in the Gospel as we now have it, but it is possible that originally they were in separate discourses. However, the fusion of the two does bring out their connection. The one prefigures the other. Moreover, in the reverse direction, so to speak, the language used to describe the day of the Lord in Joel and elsewhere is here applied to the fall of Jerusalem, the details of which must therefore not be taken too literally (24:29).

* Mt 25:29: See note on Mt 13:12.

* Mt 26:17: The passover supper was eaten this year on the Friday evening (Jn 18:28). Jesus must have anticipated the passover meal because he would be dead the following day and because the meal prefigured his death.

* Mt 26:26: The details of the Eucharist are superimposed on the ritual of the passover.

* Mt 26:51: It was Peter, as John in his later Gospel tells us (Jn 18:10), though Matthew is reluctant to say so.

* Mt 26:59: They sought evidence against him and this was necessarily false.

* Mt 26:64–65: For the first time Jesus speaks clearly of his own identity. Caiaphas evidently understands him to claim divinity.

* Mt 27:46: Jesus applies Psalm 22 (Vulgate 21) to himself.

* Mt 27:66: The sealing and guarding only helped to make the subsequent resurrection more obvious.

* Mt 28:1–20: The resurrection appearances. There are divergent traditions in the gospels, Galilean and Judean. Paul adds his own record (1 Cor 15). The accounts do not easily fit together, but this is surely evidence of their genuineness. There is no attempt to produce an artificial conformity.

Mark

* Mk 1:34: Throughout his ministry Jesus forbade the demons and those he healed of their infirmities to reveal his identity as Messiah, because the people, with their ideas of a national leader to come, were only too prone to mistake his true mission.

* Mk 2:14, *Levi*: Mark does not identify him with Matthew the apostle; cf. Mt 9:9.

* Mk 3:31, *brethren*: See note on Mt 12:46.

* Mk 4:12, *so that . . .* : One might rephrase this: "so that the Scripture might be fulfiled"; cf. Jn 18:32; 19:24, 28. It was not God's intention to prevent their understanding. Matthew avoids this difficulty by writing, "I speak to them in parables, *because* seeing they do not see" Mt 13:13).

* Mk 5:43: Knowing their nationalistic views about the Messiah to come, Jesus wished to avoid a tumult.

* Mk 7:3: Mark, writing for Gentiles, explains these Jewish customs.

* Mk 8:36, *life*: See note on Mt 16:26.

* Mk 9:13, *Elijah has come*: i.e., in the person of the Baptist Mt 11:14).

* Mk 10:24, *amazed at his words*: The Old Testament often records God's offers of material rewards for observance of his laws. This was because the future life was not yet revealed. It was therefore taken for granted, in spite of contrary evidence, that riches were a sign of God's favor.

* Mk 10:30: Some of the reward will be given in this life.

* Mk 14:13: It was unusual for a man to carry water; it was a woman's task.

* Mk 14:51–52: This young man is usually supposed to have been the evangelist himself.

* Mk 15:1: The Jews could not execute Jesus without the Roman governor's permission.

* Mk 15:40, *the younger*, or "the Less."

* Mk 16:1: There had been no time on the Friday to anoint him before the sabbath rest.

* Mk 16:9–20: This passage is regarded as inspired and canonical Scripture even if not written by Mark. As it is missing from some important manuscripts, it is possible that Mark did not write it. On the other hand, he would hardly have left his Gospel unfinished at verse 8. Many think that the original ending was lost at a very early date and that this ending was composed at the end of the apostolic period to take its place.

Luke

* Lk 1:3: Theophilus is again referred to in Acts 1:1, but nothing is known of him.

* Lk 1:5—2:52: The “Infancy Gospel,” as it is called, is written in a markedly Semitic style, which differs from that of the rest of the Gospel. It appears to be based on the reminiscences of Mary.

* Lk 1:30: The words of the angel are drawn from Messianic passages in the Old Testament.

* Lk 1:34: *How can this be*: alternate reading is *How will this be*.

* Lk 1:46–55: The Magnificat is based on the Song of Hannah (1 Sam 2:1–10), and other Old Testament passages that describe God’s favor toward Israel and especially toward the poor and lowly.

* Lk 1:69, *a horn of salvation*: i.e., a mighty savior.

* Lk 2:7, *first-born*: The term connotes possession of certain rights, privileges, and obligations; cf. Ex 13:1–2, 11–16. The word is used even in modern times without necessarily implying subsequent births.

* Lk 2:34, *for the fall*: i.e., in the sense that by rejecting his claims many would sin grievously.

* Lk 2:49: Jesus stresses the priority of his duty to his Father, which involves a high degree of independence of earthly ties.

* Lk 3:2: See note on Jn 18:13.

* Lk 3:7, *brood of vipers*: This epithet seems to have been directed mainly at the Pharisees; cf. Mt 3:7.

* Lk 3:23: This genealogy is more universalist than that of Matthew. Like Matthew, however, it gives the genealogy of Joseph, though Mary may well have been of the family of David.

* Lk 4:16–30: This account of the visit to the synagogue seems to be composed of the details of more than one visit. Luke is trying here to underline the contrast between Christ’s offer of salvation and the people’s refusal of it.

* Lk 6:20–49: Luke’s discourse is shorter than that of Matthew because it does not contain Matthew’s additional material collected from other occasions, or his details that would interest only Jews.

* Lk 7:28: John, by virtue of his office, belonged to the old dispensation, the time of preparation for the kingdom. In terms of spiritual status, even the humbler members of the kingdom were superior to him.

* Lk 7:47: The preceding parable suggests that she loved much because she had been forgiven much. Jesus now implies that her love is a sign rather than a cause of forgiveness, thus confirming the point of the parable.
* Lk 8:19, *brethren*: See note on Mt 12:46.
* Lk 8:39: There was no reason for secrecy (to avoid popular disturbance) in a non-Jewish area.
* Lk 9:51: Here begins the "Travel Narrative" of Luke, which continues up to the passion.
* Lk 9:51: *received up*: i.e., into heaven; cf. 2 Kings 2:9–11; Acts 1:2, 11. The term here includes his passion, death, resurrection, and ascension.
* Lk 9:51, 53: The Samaritans worshiped on Mount Gerizim, while orthodox Jews, of course, went to Jerusalem, and to Jerusalem only, for sacrifice.
* Lk 10:18: Jesus refers to the fall of the angels (cf. Rev 12:9), while he speaks of his conquest of the forces of evil.
* Lk 14:26: Christ's disciples must be prepared to part from any one who prevents them from serving him.
* Lk 16:8: The master commended his foresight without approving what he actually did.
* Lk 17:20: At that time many persons were expecting to see the kingdom inaugurated with striking manifestations; cf. 19:11.
* Lk 19:41–44: These moving words spoken over the city are full of scriptural allusions. Moreover, the details given could apply as well to the siege of 587 B.C. as to that of A.D. 70. It is not safe, therefore, to argue from this passage that the fall of the city had already taken place when Luke wrote his Gospel.
* Lk 20:37: As elsewhere (1 Cor 15:13–19), survival after death is linked with the resurrection of the body.
* Lk 21:24, *the times of the Gentiles*: i.e., those during which the Gentiles will take the place of the unbelieving people of Israel. Evidently, therefore, the end of the world does not coincide with the fall of Jerusalem. St. Paul says that the Jews will be converted before the end (Rom 11:26).
* Lk 22:52: Matthew and Mark describe the arrest first, before Christ's words. Luke and John both put his address to the soldiers and officials before the arrest, doubtless to stress his command over events.
* Lk 23:2: They purposely produce political charges, as these alone would interest Pilate.

* Lk 23:14: Luke, writing for Gentiles, makes it clear that Pilate wanted to release Jesus.

* Lk 23:31: One does not burn green wood. The meaning is that, if an innocent man is thus punished, what must the guilty (dry wood) expect?

* Lk 24:38: Luke stresses this episode for the benefit of his Greek readers, for whom the resurrection of the body was both impossible and absurd; cf. Acts 17:32.

THE GOSPEL ACCORDING TO JOHN

* Jn 1:1: John begins by giving his Gospel a theological background. By speaking at once of "the Word" he implies that his readers are familiar with the term. To Gentiles it indicated some form of divine revelation or self-expression. Jews would equate it with the divine Wisdom described in Proverbs, which already appears as something more than a divine quality and has some relationship with the visible world. In Sirach and Wisdom the idea is further developed. In the last-named book, Wisdom appears as a pre-existing person, taking part in the creation of the world and having a mission to reveal God to his creatures; cf. Wis 7:22—8:1.

* Jn 1:5, *light . . . darkness*: One of the familiar themes of the Gospel.

* Jn 1:29: John applies to Jesus the Messianic prophecy of Isaiah 53:6–7, perhaps worded more explicitly by the evangelist in later years.

* Jn 2:4, *What have you to do with me?*: What is that to you or to me? While this expression always implies a divergence of view, the precise meaning is to be determined by the context, which here shows that it is not an unqualified refusal, still less a rebuke.

* Jn 2:12, *brethren*: See note on Mt 12:46.

* Jn 3:22, *baptized*: A baptism like that of John. The time for baptism "in the Spirit" had not yet come.

* Jn 3:24: From the other Gospels we learn that, after John was arrested, Jesus withdrew from Judea.

* Jn 4:20, *this mountain*: Gerizim, on which the Samaritans worshiped.

* Jn 5:18, *broke the sabbath*: i.e., broke the sabbath as interpreted by them; see note on Mt 12:14.

* Jn 6:51: Jesus is the "living bread" both as Word of God (verses 32ff.) and as sacrificial victim for the salvation of man.

* Jn 6:52: A natural question to ask. Jesus answers, not by explaining it away, but by reemphasizing the reality, though not, of course, in the crude sense implied in their question.

* Jn 6:62: When Jesus ascends into heaven they will know that he spoke the truth.
* Jn 7:3, *brethren*: See note on Mt 12:46.
* Jn 7:53—8:11: This passage, though absent from some of the most ancient manuscripts, is regarded as inspired and canonical by the Church. The style suggests that it is not by St. John, and that it belongs to the Synoptic tradition.
* Jn 8:21, *die in your sin*: Theirs is that sin against the truth which is the sin against the Spirit; cf. Mt 12:31.
* Jn 8:41: They mean, "We are not idolaters," and protest their fidelity to God their Father; see notes on Rev 14:4 and 17:2.
* Jn 8:56, *he saw it* either in prophetic vision while on earth or by some special privilege after death.
* Jn 8:58: The present tense indicates Christ's eternal existence as God.
* Jn 9:3: Jesus explains in advance the purpose of the miracle.
* Jn 10:14, *the good shepherd*: The name has Messianic significance; cf. Ezek 34.
* Jn 10:18: Throughout the Gospel, Jesus insists that he is master of his own life and no one takes it from him; cf. 18:6 (at his arrest); 19:11 (before Pilate); 19:30 (on the cross).
* Jn 11:6, *stayed two days longer*: This is explained in verse 15.
* Jn 11:50: Caiaphas agreed that, as Jesus was not (in their opinion) the Messiah, any popular insurrection now could end only in disaster; so it was better, he argued, to do away with him. He was unconscious of the deeper meaning of his words, namely that Jesus must die for the salvation of man.
* Jn 12:1: Here begins the last week of Jesus' public life. This is described in great detail, as was the first week in chapter 1.
* Jn 12:32, *lifted up*: i.e., on the cross; but the words also contain a reference to his going up into heaven. The two mysteries are inseparable.
* Jn 13:1: John begins here to unfold the mystery of the love of Jesus for "his own." Note the solemn introduction to the "hour" of his passion and death.
* Jn 13:34, *new commandment*: Jesus gives a new depth to the familiar commandment of the Old Testament. The standard now is, "as I have loved you."
* Jn 14:26, *all things*: After Jesus has gone to his Father, the Holy Spirit will complete his revelation to the world.

* Jn 15:18: Jesus contrasts the love his disciples have with the hatred the world bears them.
* Jn 16:10: Jesus is taken from them because they did not receive him.
* Jn 17:1–26: The priestly prayer of Jesus, before his sacrifice.
* Jn 17:5 declares his pre-existence.
* Jn 18:13: According to Jewish law the high-priesthood was for life. The Romans had deposed Annas, the legal holder, in A.D. 15, and appointed another in his place, but many Jews continued to recognize Annas.
* Jn 18:28: They would have contracted a legal impurity by entering the house of a pagan.
* Jn 18:29: See note on Lk 23:2.
* Jn 18:31: Crucifixion was a Roman, not a Jewish, punishment.
* Jn 19:7: At last, because of Pilate's reluctance, they produce the real charge.
* Jn 19:8–9: Pilate is afraid and asks Jesus where he comes from—not his country, but his mysterious origins, as implied in the charge.
* Jn 19:27, *took her to his own home*: Joseph must now have been dead.
* Jn 20:17: The death and resurrection of Jesus had put an end to the ordinary familiar relationships of human life, and the time of lasting companionship had not yet come.
* Jn 21:1–25: This chapter was added later, either by the evangelist or by a disciple; cf. 20:3–31 and 21:24.
* Jn 21:7: John remembered a similar miracle before; cf. Lk 5:6.
* Jn 21:15–17: The threefold question addressed to Peter alone corresponds to the threefold denial. Jesus gives Peter charge over his flock.

THE ACTS OF THE APOSTLES

* Acts 1:1, *the first book*: i.e., St. Luke's Gospel.
* Acts 1:14, *brethren*: See note on Mt 12:46.
* Acts 1:22: An apostle must be a witness to Christ's resurrection.
* Acts 2:14: Peter assumes the leadership in public. In this discourse we have the earliest form of the apostolic preaching.
* Acts 3:1: In the early days, the first Christians observed the prescriptions of the Jewish law.
* Acts 4:2: The Sadducees did not believe in the resurrection of the dead.
* Acts 4:32, *everything in common*: They freely shared what was theirs individually; cf. Acts 5:4.

* Acts 5:11, *Church*: i.e., the Christian and Messianic community; a term borrowed from the Old Testament.

* Acts 5:20, *Life*: cf. Acts 9:2, “the Way.” These terms recall the words of Jesus, “I am the way, and the truth, and the life” (Jn 14:6).

* Acts 5:34, *Gamaliel*: Teacher of St. Paul; cf. Acts 22:3.

* Acts 6:1, *Hellenists*: Greek-speaking Jews of the Dispersion, who had their own synagogues in Jerusalem and read the Scriptures in Greek.

* Acts 8:20: Hence the word “simony,” meaning “buying and selling spiritual powers and privileges.”

* Acts 9:5: Jesus identifies himself with his followers.

* Acts 9:13, *saints*: i.e., Christians, made holy by baptism.

* Acts 10:16: The vision was to prepare Peter for his reception of Cornelius the Gentile and his household into the Church; cf. also Acts 15.

* Acts 12:1: The second wave of persecution: cf. Acts 8:1.

* Acts 13:16–41: This first recorded sermon of Paul is similar to that of Peter in Acts 2:14–36.

* Acts 16:10: This is the first of the passages in Acts in which the story is told in the first person plural, indicating that Luke, the author, was there. The manuscript Codex Bezae, however, has a “we” passage in 11:28.

* Acts 16:13: Being a Roman colony, Philippi had no synagogue within its walls.

* Acts 19:35, *the sacred stone* or statue of the goddess which, according to legend, came down from heaven. Possibly a meteorite.

* Acts 20:7: Celebration of the Eucharist on the Lord’s day, i.e., Saturday evening, according to the Jewish way of reckoning a day from sunset to sunset.

* Acts 20:34: Paul insisted on working for his living, though recognizing the apostle’s right to support by the faithful; cf. 1 Cor 9:4–7.

* Acts 21:4, *told Paul not to go*: This was not a command. The Holy Spirit enlightened them about what lay before Paul and they naturally wished to spare him; cf. verse 11.

* Acts 22:20, *your witness*: Greek, “martyr.” Witnessing by one’s death (i.e., martyrdom) is the supreme example.

THE LETTER OF PAUL TO THE ROMANS

* Rom 1:1–7: The opening address and salutation are very much in the style of contemporary letter-writing, giving the name of the sender and recipient, and following this with greetings.

* Rom 1:10: Paul did not found the church at Rome.
* Rom 1:13, *harvest*: Perhaps those who founded the church at Rome had confined themselves largely to Jews and had not made much headway with Gentiles.
* Rom 3:27: Above all, it is faith, not works alone, that will justify both Jew and Gentile, and (as is made clear later) faith in Jesus.
* Rom 5:12: Physical death is a sign of spiritual death; though physical death remains after justification.
* Rom 5:15: The *felix culpa* praised in the *Exsultet* at the Easter Vigil.
* Rom 6:4, *buried*: Immersed in the water of baptism.
* Rom 6:15: As before, in the case of the law (Rom 2:17–29), so now, in the case of grace, Paul says it is not a license to sin.
* Rom 7:13–25: Man under the law of Moses and perhaps man under the natural law too.
* Rom 8:19: Material creation, too, shares man's destiny, made as it was for him. Many ancient philosophers thought matter to be evil and that the spirit should be freed from it.
* Rom 9:19–24: Paul's words here, taken by themselves, seem to leave no room for moral responsibility, but they must be taken in conjunction with other passages; see chapters 1 and 2.
* Rom 10:1: Paul is afraid he has spoken too strongly of their sins, so he declares his love for Israel.
* Rom 14:1—15:13: Paul is tolerant of the Jewish Christians' reluctance to abandon the ritual prescriptions of the law of Moses, while being equally insistent that these shall not be forced on Gentile Christians.
* Rom 14:14: Conscience is the ultimate guide.
* Rom 15:15–16: Paul again justifies his writing to a church he did not found.
* Rom 16:16, *All the churches of Christ greet you*: A remarkable salutation, not used elsewhere.

THE FIRST LETTER OF PAUL TO THE CORINTHIANS

* 1 Cor 1:2, *saints*: A word commonly used for Christians in Paul's letters and in Acts.
* 1 Cor 1:12, *Cephas*: i.e., Peter. It does not follow from this that he had even been to Corinth, but it does indicate his authority there.
* 1 Cor 2:1–2: Paul's failure at Athens convinced him that lofty words and worldly wisdom were less effective than Jesus crucified.

* 1 Cor 3:13, *the Day*: i.e., the day of the Lord, God's searching judgment.
* 1 Cor 3:16, *God's temple*: The dignity of the Christians.
* 1 Cor 5:1, *father's wife*: Evidently his stepmother.
* 1 Cor 5:5, *to Satan*: Not only excommunicated, but in some sense given over to suffering, for his own good.
* 1 Cor 5:9–10, *immoral*: Literally, "fornicators."
* 1 Cor 5:11, *guilty of immorality*: Literally, "a fornicator."
* 1 Cor 6:1, *the unrighteous*: i.e., civil courts in which the judges were, of course, pagan.
* 1 Cor 6:9: *the immoral*: literally, "fornicators."
* 1 Cor 6:9: *homosexuals*: Greek has "effeminate nor sodomites." The apostle condemns, not the inherent tendencies of such, but the indulgence of them.
* 1 Cor 6:12: This saying is possibly an exaggeration of the freedom from the Mosaic law that Christians enjoyed. The saying has been applied to sinful practices, as is clear from the following verses.
* 1 Cor 6:13, 18, *immorality*: i.e., sexual immorality.
* 1 Cor 7:2: Note Paul's insistence on equality of man and woman in certain aspects of Christian marriage, and his recognition that the unmarried state is also a gift from God.
* 1 Cor 8:1–13: Animals sacrificed to pagan gods were often sold as meat in the market. Could Christians buy such meat? Paul allows it so long as scandal is avoided.
* 1 Cor 9:3: Paul set great store by the fact that he has earned his living and waived his right to support by the faithful. He used this as an authentication of his apostolate.
* 1 Cor 9:5, *wife*: Greek, a "woman," a "sister." This could mean either a woman who is a Christian or a wife who is a Christian. There were pious women who ministered to the apostles (Lk 8:3). As many of the apostles must have been married, they may have been ministered to by their wives, though it is possible they had left their wives in answer to the Lord's command to leave all (Lk 18:28–29).
* 1 Cor 9:5, *brethren*: See note on Mt 12:46.
* 1 Cor 10:20: Paul appears to forbid partaking in sacrificial meals. In verse 27 he says they may eat meat offered to idols if it is at an ordinary meal, unless it would cause scandal to anyone present.

* 1 Cor 11:20: There was apparently a common meal before the Eucharist at which food and drink were to be shared. Paul condemns the abuses that had crept in.
* 1 Cor 12:1: The spiritual gifts here referred to were common in the first age of the Church and helped to establish it on a firm basis.
* 1 Cor 12:31: Love, however, is far superior to these gifts.
* 1 Cor 15:13: Again, the resurrection of the dead is linked with Christ's resurrection; cf. Rom 8:11.
* 1 Cor 15:29: Apparently a custom of vicarious baptism for those who had died without it. Paul mentions it without approving it.
* 1 Cor 16:1: The collection to be made everywhere for the poor Christians in Jerusalem.

THE SECOND LETTER OF PAUL TO THE CORINTHIANS

* 2 Cor 1:8, *affliction*: Possibly the disturbance at Ephesus (Acts 19:23–41), or perhaps a serious illness.
* 2 Cor 3:18: Cleansed in baptism through the power of the Holy Spirit, our soul shines with the reflected glory of God.
* 2 Cor 4:7, *this treasure*: i.e., the apostolate.
* 2 Cor 4:12: i.e., we suffer, if necessary, even unto death, that you may have (spiritual) life.
* 2 Cor 5:19: Or, "God was reconciling the world to himself through Christ."
* 2 Cor 5:21, *made him to be sin*: i.e., "sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and for sin, he condemned sin in the flesh" (Rom 8:3).
* 2 Cor 9:1, *superfluous*: Yet Paul goes on to do so at some length, exhorting them to be generous.
* 2 Cor 10:1: Paul is referring ironically to what some people are saying about him; see verse 10.
* 2 Cor 12:7, *a thorn*: Perhaps some form of sickness or disability, or the opposition of Israel to his teaching.
* 2 Cor 12:13: Paul ironically asks forgiveness for not being a charge on them as the other apostles were.

THE LETTER OF PAUL TO THE GALATIANS

* Gal 1:6: After the greeting there is no commendation, as was usual, but rather strong rebuke.

* Gal 1:10: No doubt Paul was accused of exempting Gentile converts from the law of Moses in order to curry favor.
* Gal 1:19: *Lord's brother*: See the note on *brethren* at Mt 12:46 above.
* Gal 2:16, *works of the law*: Paul is contrasting not faith with good works but faith in Jesus Christ with observance of the law of Moses.
* Gal 3:2, *Spirit*: He probably refers to the outward manifestations of the Spirit, such as the gift of tongues.
* Gal 5:11, *stumbling block of the cross*: So far as the Jews were concerned, this would consist largely in the exemption of converts from the obligations of the law of Moses.

THE LETTER OF PAUL TO THE EPHESIANS

* Eph 1:1, *To the saints who are*: The addition "at Ephesus" is doubtful. The letter may have been a form of encyclical.
* Eph 1:10, *to unite*: Or, "to sum up." This is one of the chief themes of the letter. Men are to be under Christ as head of the Mystical Body, and even irrational creatures must be in some way under him as the cornerstone of creation.
* Eph 2:14, *dividing wall*: A metaphor taken from the wall that divided the court of the Gentiles from the court of the Israelites in the temple.
* Eph 3:3, *the mystery*: i.e., that the Gentiles were to be admitted to the Church on the basis of equality.
* Eph 5:14: Apparently a fragment of an early Christian hymn; cf. 1 Tim 3:16.

THE LETTER OF PAUL TO THE PHILIPPIANS

* Phil 1:14, *because of my imprisonment*: i.e., because I continue to preach in their midst, though in prison.
* Phil 1:20, *honored in my body*: i.e., through my sufferings.
* Phil 2:6, *in the form of God*: The Greek shows that divine attributes, and therefore nature, are implied here. It is not the divine nature he set no store by, but equality of treatment and recognition of his divinity.
* Phil 2:7, *emptied himself* of this external recognition, which was his right.
* Phil 3:12, *made me his own*: On the road to Damascus.
* Phil 3:19: These Judaizers made holiness a question of distinction of foods and set great store by circumcision.

THE LETTER OF PAUL TO THE COLOSSIANS

* Col 1:15, *first-born*: Born of the Father before all ages. The reference here is to the divine person of the Word; see verse 16.
* Col 1:18: His human nature.
* Col 1:24, *what is lacking*: Christ's sufferings were, of course, sufficient for our redemption, but all of us may add ours to his, in order that the fruits of his redemption be applied to the souls of men.
* Col 3:18—4:5: The whole passage corresponds closely to Eph 5:22—6:9.
* Col 4:10: Mark, the evangelist, and, probably, the John Mark of Acts 12:12, 25.
* Col 4:14: Luke, the evangelist.

THE FIRST LETTER OF PAUL TO THE THESSALONIANS

* 1 Thess 1:1: Paul joins with himself two who had evangelized Thessalonica with him.
* 1 Thess 2:18, *I, Paul*: He distinguishes himself from Silvanus and Timothy.
* 1 Thess 4:3, *sanctification*: With special reference to the practice of purity, specially difficult to those newly converted from paganism.
* 1 Thess 4:3, *immorality*: i.e., sexual immorality.
* 1 Thess 4:11: The Thessalonians thought that the second Coming of Christ was at hand and tended to neglect their daily duties. He corrects this misconception.
* 1 Thess 4:13: Paul tells them that those who died before Christ's second Coming are no worse off than those who will still be alive at his coming.
* 1 Thess 4:17: i.e., we who are alive shall go out to meet him and accompany him back on his return to this earth.

THE SECOND LETTER OF PAUL TO THE THESSALONIANS

* 2 Thess 2:2: Paul warns against over-eagerness to expect the second Coming, and specifies various signs to be looked for first.
* 2 Thess 2:3, *the man of lawlessness*: i.e., Antichrist.
* 2 Thess 2:7: Evil will operate secretly till the final unmasking.

THE FIRST LETTER OF PAUL TO TIMOTHY

* 1 Tim 1:2: Timothy, son of a Greek father and a Jewish mother, was already a Christian when Paul met him (Acts 16:1). A close association ensued.

* 1 Tim 1:4, *myths and endless genealogies*: A reference to the Jewish legends and spurious pedigrees added by false Judaizers to the Biblical narratives; cf. the Book of Jubilees.

* 1 Tim 1:20, *delivered to Satan*: A form of excommunication; see note on 1 Cor 5:5.

* 1 Tim 2:6, *ransom for all*: This is why Paul wants prayers for all (verse 1).

* 1 Tim 3:1, *bishop*: At this time an office probably not distinct from that of priest.

* 1 Tim 3:11, *women*: i.e., deaconesses.

* 1 Tim 4:3, *forbid marriage*: As some Gnostics did.

* 1 Tim 4:3, *abstinence from foods*: As practiced by Judaizers.

* 1 Tim 5:3, *real widows*: i.e., with no one to help and support them.

* 1 Tim 5:12: Paul had no objection to widows marrying again; cf. 1 Cor 7:8–9. But the widows here had clearly made some sort of vow or promise to serve the Church in singleness. Paul recommended that younger widows should marry again (verse 14).

THE SECOND LETTER OF PAUL TO TIMOTHY

* 2 Tim 1:15, *Asia*: The Roman province of that name, now in western Turkey.

* 2 Tim 2:18: They explained the resurrection by saying it was the rising to newness of life in baptism, thus ignoring a bodily resurrection, a doctrine the Greeks found very hard to accept; cf. Acts 17:32.

* 2 Tim 3:16: Paul refers to the Old Testament Scriptures.

* 2 Tim 4:6, *on the point of being sacrificed*: Literally, “poured out in sacrifice” as a drink-offering or libation.

* 2 Tim 4:21, *Linus*: According to tradition, the successor of Peter in the see of Rome.

THE LETTER OF PAUL TO TITUS

* Tit 1:5, *elders*: Each Christian community was ruled by a body of elders.

* Tit 2:13, *God and Savior*: Both terms appear to refer to Jesus Christ.

* Tit 3:5–7: A brief and clear statement of the doctrine of justification.

THE LETTER TO THE HEBREWS

* Heb 1:1–4: A contrast between the progressive and piecemeal revelation of the old dispensation and the complete revelation of the new

given by a single representative—no mere prophet but the Son of God himself.

* Heb 2:2, *angels*: The covenant of Sinai was thought to have been given through the angels.

* Heb 2:10, *suffering*: The divinely appointed means of progress toward God; cf. verse 18.

* Heb 3:11: Those who murmured against God in the desert were excluded from the promised land (the "rest"). Christians should beware lest, by offending God, they be excluded from heaven, the true rest, of which the promised land was a type.

* Heb 5:1–5: If Jesus was to be mediator, he had to have a human nature like ours, and, moreover, he could not appoint himself, but had to be appointed by God.

* Heb 6:4, *impossible*: The apostasy referred to in verse 6 is clearly thought of as so deliberate as to preclude any real possibility of repentance; or there may be a reference here to the impossibility of being baptized a second time.

* Heb 7:3, *without father*: i.e., the father is not mentioned in Scripture.

* Heb 7:3, *neither beginning of days nor end of life*: So too here, they are not mentioned in Scripture either. Thus his priesthood can be taken to foreshadow or symbolize the Christian priesthood. "You are a priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek" (Ps 110:4; cf. Heb 7:17).

* Heb 8:11: This verse means merely that knowledge of God will be commonly shared. It does not exclude the existence of a ministry of teaching in the Messianic times.

* Heb 10:1ff.: The sacrifices of the old law, being imperfect, were repeated and did at least keep alive a sense of sin. Contrast with Christ's sacrifice (verse 14).

* Heb 11:6: Here is stated the minimum necessary for salvation.

* Heb 12:1ff.: After explaining in the preceding chapters how we are redeemed through faith in Jesus Christ, the author now exhorts his readers to run the race with perseverance.

* Heb 13:1ff.: Moral exhortation.

* Heb 13:9: Again the warning against false doctrine, especially the Judaizers' teachings; cf. Phil 3:19; 1 Tim 1:4; 4:3.

* Heb 13:13: i.e., "Let us leave the observance of Judaism behind us."

THE LETTER OF JAMES

* Jas 1:1, *twelve tribes*: i.e., Jewish Christians outside Palestine.
* Jas 1:22: This is the main theme of the letter.
* Jas 2:1–7: These are hard words, but no harder than those of Jesus.
* Jas 2:10: In keeping the law, we must keep *the whole law*. We cannot pick and choose.
* Jas 2:14: Good works are necessary besides faith.
* Jas 5:3: The "treasure" they have laid up is described in the following verses.
* Jas 5:13–15: This passage is the scriptural basis for the sacrament of anointing the sick.

THE FIRST LETTER OF PETER

* 1 Pet 1:1: See note on Jas 1:1. Baptism is the main theme of this letter which, in fact, may have been a baptismal address.
* 1 Pet 1:11, *Spirit of Christ*: Christ, as the eternally existing Word, is envisaged as inspiring the prophets of old.
* 1 Pet 3:1–6: Peter's teaching on the behavior and status of women corresponds to that of Paul, though without Paul's forthrightness.
* 1 Pet 4:1, *ceased from sin*: Peter means that a continual acceptance of suffering is incompatible with a proneness to sin.
* 1 Pet 5:13, *Babylon*: Rome was as full of iniquity as ancient Babylon; cf. Rev 17:9.

THE SECOND LETTER OF PETER

* 2 Pet 1:4, *partakers of the divine nature*: A strong expression to describe the transformation of human nature by divine grace.
* 2 Pet 1:16–18: A reference to the transfiguration.
* 2 Pet 2:3: Much of the material of this chapter appears to be from the Letter of Jude.
* 2 Pet 3:16, *this* seems to refer to the theme of the end of the world and the second Coming of Christ, about which Paul had written in his letters to the Thessalonians.

THE FIRST LETTER OF JOHN

* 1 Jn 1:1–7: Note the likeness with John's Gospel 1:1–18.
* 1 Jn 1:3, *fellowship*: A Johannine theme.
* 1 Jn 1:5, *light . . . darkness*: Another familiar theme in John's Gospel.
* 1 Jn 2:3: Cf. the words of Jesus, "If you love me, you will keep my commandments" (Jn 14:15).

* 1 Jn 2:18, *the last hour*: John exhorts his readers to hold fast, as though the end were at hand.

* 1 Jn 3:6, *sins*: i.e., remains in sin, or has a habit of sin.

* 1 Jn 4:1, *test the spirits*: i.e., examine those who claim to have special gifts from the Holy Spirit; cf. 1 Cor 14:32.

* 1 Jn 5:8: This reads as follows in the Vulgate: “ [7]There are three who give testimony in heaven: the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit; and these three are one. [8]And there are three that give testimony on earth: the spirit, and the water, and the blood; and these three are one.” The “Three Heavenly Witnesses,” as the first sentence is called, is first found in the Latin (fourth century) and does not appear in any Greek manuscript until the fifteenth century. It is probably a marginal gloss that found its way into the text.

THE SECOND LETTER OF JOHN

* 2 Jn 1: *The elder*: Perhaps the head of the group or “college” of elders that presided over each Christian community. John was head not only of the Ephesus community but of all the communities in the province of Asia.

* 2 Jn 1: *the elect lady*: Probably not an individual lady but a particular church or community in Asia.

* 2 Jn 13: *children*: i.e., the Christians of Ephesus.

THE THIRD LETTER OF JOHN

* 3 Jn 12: *Demetrius*: Evidently a leading Christian, recommended to Gaius.

THE LETTER OF JUDE

* Jude 6: It is not clear to what Jude refers. Perhaps Gen 6:2 or the apocryphal Enoch 6–15.

* Jude 9: Apparently a reference to another apocryphal work, the Assumption of Moses.

THE REVELATION TO JOHN

* Rev 1:4–8: Describes the glorious coming and reign of the Messiah.

* Rev 1:13, *Son of man* refers to Dan 7:13. The Messiah is described in symbolic terms.

* Rev 2:10, *ten days*: Not literally. It means the persecution will be short.

* Rev 2:20–21, *immorality* here seems to mean idolatry rather than sexual excess.

* Rev 2:24, *deep things of Satan*: The doctrines of the Nicolaitans. *They* called them the “deep things of God.”

* Rev 2:28, *morning star*: Probably Christ himself.
* Rev 3:12, *new name*: cf. Is 62:2. Perhaps it was "the Word," or perhaps it is not to be revealed till the last day.
* Rev 4:3: John describes God in symbolic terms.
* Rev 4:4, *elders*: They perform a priestly and royal task, since they praise God and share in the government of the world.
* Rev 4:6, *four living creatures*: cf. Ezek 1:4–25: the four angels who preside over the government of the world. But in Christian tradition these symbols are used for the four evangelists.
* Rev 4:8, *Holy, holy, holy*: Quoted in the *Sanctus* at Mass.
* Rev 5:1, *a scroll*: This contained God's designs, kept secret till now; being written on both sides, nothing could be added.
* Rev 5:6: The seven horns and seven eyes symbolize Christ's full power and knowledge.
* Rev 6:1: Begins the account of the destruction of the Roman Empire (chapters 6–9).
* Rev 6:5, *balance*: Symbol of famine. The balance was to measure rations.
* Rev 7:4, *a hundred and forty-four thousand*: A symbolic number, i.e., twelve (the sacred number) squared and multiplied by 1,000 to denote a multitude. It is the Church, the spiritual Israel, that is meant.
* Rev 7:14, *the great tribulation*: The Neronian persecution?
* Rev 8:5: Coals from the altar of burnt offering were brought to the altar of incense.
* Rev 9:1, *star*: A fallen angel.
* Rev 9:14, *Euphrates*: The region of the Parthians.
* Rev 9:21, *immorality*: See note on 2:20–21.
* Rev 10:7, *mystery of God*: i.e., the establishment of the kingdom of God following on the destruction of Israel's enemies.
* Rev 10:9, *bitter . . . sweet*: The scroll related both the sufferings and the victories of Christ's Church.
* Rev 11:1–19: The Jerusalem here described stands for the Church, which is to be persecuted by the Romans.
* Rev 11:2: The three and a half years' persecution of the Jews by Antiochus Epiphanes, 168–165 b.c., had become the standard time of a persecution. Three and a half years equals 42 months equals 1,260 days (verse 3).

* Rev 11:3, *two witnesses*: As they have yet to die, possibly they are Elijah and Enoch.
* Rev 11:8, *the great city*: i.e., Rome.
* Rev 12:1–6: The *child* brought forth is the Messiah; the *dragon* is the devil; the *woman* who gave birth to the Messiah is Israel, and then becomes the Christian Church, which continually gives birth to the faithful.
* Rev 12:14, *a time, and times, and half a time*: This is the three and a half years of 11:2.
* Rev 12:17: Mary, the mother of the Messiah, must also be included in the meaning.
* Rev 13:1, *a beast*: This symbolizes the material forces of evil, arrayed against the Church.
* Rev 13:11, *another beast*: i.e., the false prophets.
* Rev 13:18, *six hundred and sixty-six*: The letters of Nero's name plus the title of Caesar, given their numerical meaning in Hebrew and added together, make 666.
* Rev 14:4: Although tradition tends to take this literally, the context and Old Testament metaphor suggest that it means they have kept free from idolatry.
* Rev 14:8, *Babylon*: i.e., Rome.
* Rev 15:3–4: The song of Moses in Ex 15:1–18 celebrated victory over Pharaoh. This is seen as foreshadowing the triumph of the Lamb.
* Rev 16:14, *the great day*: On which all the Gentile armies shall be gathered to give battle.
* Rev 16:16, *Armageddon*: i.e., Megiddo, where Josiah was defeated by the king of Egypt, cf. 2 Kings 23:29.
* Rev 17:1, *great harlot*: i.e., Rome.
* Rev 17:2, *fornication*: i.e., idolatry.
* Rev 18:11–20: The description abruptly assumes the language of Ezekiel's prophecy of the destruction of Tyre, another city notorious for its sins (Ezek 27:1—28:19).
* Rev 19:7, *marriage of the Lamb*: i.e., final establishment of the kingdom of God. The spouse is the Church.
* Rev 20:3: The destruction of the dragon must coincide in time with that of the beast (19:20), so that the first resurrection with the reign of the martyrs refers to the revival and expansion of the Church after the years of persecution.

* Rev 21:1: Creation will be renewed one day, freed from corruption and illumined by God's glory.

* Rev 21:8, *second death*: i.e., eternal damnation.

EXEGETICAL NOTES

THE BOOK OF GENESIS

[a] Or *When God began to create*. Back to text.

[b] Or *wind*. Back to text.

[c] Or *flood*. Back to text.

[d] Heb *ishshah*. Back to text.

[e] Heb *ish*. Back to text.

[f] The name in Hebrew resembles the word for *living*. Back to text.

[g] Heb *qanah*, get. Back to text.

[h] Sam Gk Syr Compare Vg: Heb lacks *Let us go out to the field*. Back to text.

[i] Gk Syr Vg: Heb *Therefore*. Back to text.

[j] That is *Wandering*. Back to text.

[k] Or *window*. Back to text.

[l] Gk: Heb repeats *every beast of the earth*. Back to text.

[m] Or *Blessed be the* LORD, *the God of Shem*. Back to text.

[n] Compare verses 20, 31. Heb lacks *These are the sons of Japheth*. Back to text.

[o] That is *Division*. Back to text.

[p] Compare Heb *balal*, confuse. Back to text.

[q] Or *in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed*. Back to text.

[r] Or *Terebinth*. Back to text.

[s] Or *Terebinths*. Back to text.

[t] That is *God hears*. Back to text.

[u] Cn: Heb *have I even here seen after him who sees me?* Back to text.

[v] That is *the well of one who sees and lives*. Back to text.

[w] Heb *El Shaddai*. Back to text.

[x] That is *exalted father*. Back to text.

[y] Here taken to mean *father of a multitude*. Back to text.

[z] That is *he laughs*. Back to text.

[a] Or *Terebinths*. Back to text.

[b] Heb *seahs*. Back to text.